

Chapter 1

The Tao that can be understood cannot be the primal, or cosmic, Tao, just as an idea that can be expressed in words cannot be the infinite idea. And yet this ineffable Tao was the source of all spirit and matter, and being expressed was the mother of all created things.

The Tao that can be defined is not the real Tao. The name that can be named is not the real Name. The unnamable [Tao] is the source of Heaven and Earth. Naming is the mother of all particular things.

The Tao that is the subject of discussion is not the true Tao. The quality which can be named is not its true attribute. That which was before Heaven and Earth is called the Non-Existent. The Existent is the mother of all things.

Existence is beyond the power of words
To define: Terms may be used But are none of them absolute.

The Tao that can be expressed in words is not the eternal Tao. The name that can be defined in words is not the name that never changes. Non-existence is what we will call the source of heaven and earth. Existence is the mother of all things. From eternal non-existence, therefore, we observe the beginning of the existence of the many hidden qualities of the universe.

Therefore not to desire the things of sense is to know the freedom of spirituality; and to desire is to learn the limitation of matter. These two things spirit and matter, so different in nature, have the same origin. This unity of origin is the mystery of mysteries, but it is the gateway to spirituality. up

Free from desire, you experience reality. Trapped in desire, you see only appearances. Reality and appearance have different names, but they emerge from the same source [i.e., the Tao]. This source is called darkness, deep darkness; and yet it is the way to all wisdom. up

Therefore doth the wise man seek after the first mystery of the Non-Existent, while seeing in that which exists the Ultimates thereof. The Non-Existent and Existent are identical in all but name. This identity of apparent opposites I call the profound, the great deep, the open door of bewilderment. up

From eternal existence, therefore, we clearly observe the overt qualities of the universe. These two, the hidden and the overt, are originally the same at source, and become different when they manifest themselves. This same origin is "the smallest of the small." The absolute "smallest of the small" is the gate from which the beginning of all the parts of the universe emerges. up

Chapter 2

When every one recognizes beauty to be only a masquerade, then it is simply ugliness. In the same way goodness, if it is not sincere, is not goodness. So existence and non-existence are incompatible. The difficult and easy are mutually opposites. Just as the long and the short, the high and the low, the loud and soft, the before and the behind, are all opposites and each reveals the other.	No beauty without ugliness. No good without evil. Being and non-being are two aspects of the same reality. Difficult and easy, long and short, high and low, before and after: With each pair, two sides of the same coin.. Therefore, the TaoMaster acts with non-do [wuwei] and teaches without speaking.	When the world speaks of beauty as being beautiful, ugliness is at once defined. When goodness is seen to be good, evil is at once apparent. So do existence and non-existence mutually give rise to one another, as that which is difficult and that which is easy, distant and near, high and low, shrill and bass, preceding and following.	People through finding something beautiful Think something else unbeautiful, Through finding one man fit Judge another unfit.	
Therefore the wise man is not conspicuous in his affairs or given to much talking. Though troubles arise he is not irritated. He produces but does not own; he acts but claims no merit; he builds but does not dwell therein; and because he does not dwell therein he never departs. up	Things come and go. He lets them come and go. He creates, but he does not own. He achieves, but he takes no credit. He completes his work and then forgets about it. Practice non-do, and your accomplishments endure. up	The Sage therefore is occupied only with that which is without prejudice. He teaches without verbosity; he acts without effort; he produces with possessing, he acts without regard to the fruit of action; he brings his work to perfection without assuming credit; and claiming nothing as his own, he cannot at any time be said to lose. up		Everything in the universe, when defined, is relative to everything else. The sage does not try to differentiate things, he does not try to show his preference for things either in deed or in speech. This does not mean that the sage does nothing or says nothing; rather, it means that he "accepts things as they are," easily and naturally, without making any demands. up

Chapter 3

Neglecting to praise the worthy deters people from emulating them; just as not prizing rare treasures deters a man from becoming a thief; or ignoring the things which awaken desire keeps the heart at rest. Therefore the wise ruler does not suggest unnecessary things, but seeks to satisfy the minds of his people.

Glorify the superior, hatch jealousy and competition. Value possessions, provoke stealing. Stimulate desire, enflame the passions. Therefore, the Taoist Master would rule by emptying minds and filling bellies, by weakening desire and strengthening bodies.

Avoiding distinctions of merit among the people prevents jealousy. Not setting a value on rare things prevents theft. Not seeking the things of peace keeps the mind in peace.

It is better not to make merit a matter of reward
Lest people conspire and contend,
Not to pile up rich belongings
Lest they rob,
Not to excite by display
Lest they covet.

He seeks to allay appetites but strengthen bones. He ever tries by keeping people in ignorance to keep them satisfied and those who have knowledge he restrains from evil. If he, himself, practices restraint then everything is in quietness. up

He would lead the people away from knowing and wanting and would try to prevent those with knowledge from interfering. Practice non-do, and everything will fall into place. up

Thus the Sage governs by ridding the heart of its desires; giving the stomach due satisfaction, by resting the muscles and strengthening the bones, by preserving the world from a knowledge of evil and hence from its desire, and by making those who have such knowledge afraid to use it. He acts by non-action, and by this he governs all. up

A sound leader's aim is to open people's hearts, Fill their stomachs, Calm their wills, Brace their bones And so to clarify their thoughts and cleanse their needs That no cunning meddler could touch them: Without being forced, without strain or constraint, Good government comes of itself.

He governs by non-action, And therefore, there is nothing that cannot be done. Non-quiet and non-order in the world are caused by ambition to attain the unattainable, and by plotting to go from the undesired to the desired. If people would obey the laws of the world the way the sage does, there would always be balance between body and soul, and peace and serenity would abound in the world. up

Chapter 4

The Tao appears to be emptiness but it is never exhausted. Oh, it is profound! It appears to have preceded everything. It dulls its own sharpness, unravels its own fetters, softens its own brightness, identifies itself with its own dust.

The Tao is empty: used but never used up. It is the bottomless source of all things. It blunts sharp edges, unties knots, softens glare, clears dust.

Tao is without limitation; its depth is the source of whatsoever is. It makes sharp things round, it brings order out of chaos, it obscures the brilliant, it is wholly without attachment.

Existence, by nothing bred, Breeds everything. Parent of the universe, It smooths rough edges, Unties hard knots, Tempers the sharp sun, Lays blowing dust, Its image in the wellspring never fails.

The Tao, if you examine it, will always be empty and will never be full. In its infinite emptiness lies the source of all things, It will remain in its depths forever.

Oh, it is tranquil! It appears infinite; I do not know from what it proceeds. It even appears to be antecedent to the Lord. up

It is hidden, but always present. I don't know its mother. It is older than the gods [if there are any gods]. up

I do not know who gave it birth; it is more ancient than God. up

But how was it conceived?--this image Of no other sire.

I don't know whose seed it is, But it looks like the predecessor of the universe itself. up

Chapter 5

Heaven and earth are not like humans, they are impartial. They regard all things as insignificant, as though they were playthings made of straw. The wise man is also impartial. To him all men are alike and unimportant.

The Tao is impartial; it sees all things as straw [fake] dogs. The Taoist Master is also impartial; he regards people as straw dogs.

Neither Heaven nor Earth has any predilections; they regard all persons and things as sacrificial images. The wise man knows no distinctions; he beholds all men as things made for holy uses.

Nature, immune as to a sacrifice of straw dogs, Faces the decay of its fruits. A sound man, immune as to a sacrifice of straw dogs, Faces the passing of human generations.

Heaven and earth do not own all things, For them, things are like straw dogs. The sage does not own his words, For him, all people are like straw dogs. The hollow space that lies between heaven and earth is like the blacksmith's bellows.

The space between heaven and earth is like a bellows, it is empty but does not collapse; it moves and more and more issues. A gossip is soon empty, it is doubtful if he can be impartial. up

The Tao is like a bellows: it is empty yet infinitely available. It is always producing. Speak of it, fail to grasp it. Hold on to the center. up

The celestial space is like unto bellows though containing nothing that is solid, it does not at any time collapse; and the more it is set in motion, the more does it produce. The inflated man, however, is soon exhausted. Than self-restraint there is nothing better. up

The universe, like a bellows, Is always emptying, always full: The more it yields, the more it holds. Men came to their wit's end arguing about it And had better meet it at the marrow.

Hollow in appearance, nothing is lacking, And if it moves, a lot of what is in it moves. The person who speaks a lot will be exhausted. It would be better for him to keep his words to himself. up

Chapter 6

The Spirit of the perennial spring is said to be immortal, she is called the Mysterious One.	The valley spirit, the Great Mother: Her doorway is the channel from which Heaven and Earth came forth.	Like the river in the valley, the spirit is never dried up. I call it the Mother-Deep.	The breath of life moves through a deathless valley Of mysterious motherhood Which conceives and bears the universal seed, The seeming of a world never to end, Breath for men to draw from as they will: And the more they take of it, the more remains.	"The valley and the wind will never die." They are the creators of the one who is the mystical mother, The one whose hair is the source of heaven and earth.
The Mysterious One is typical of the source of heaven and earth. It is continually and endlessly issuing and without effort. up	She is always present and inexhaustible. up	The motion of the Mother-Deep I regard as the origin of the Heaven and the Earth. Forever it endures and moves without design. up		This source will never end. Even if it is exploited endlessly, it will never diminish. up

Chapter 7

Heaven is eternal, earth is lasting. The reason why heaven and earth are eternal and lasting is because they do not live for themselves; that is the reason they will ever endure.

Heaven and Earth are everlasting. Since they were never born, they will never die. They do not exist for themselves and thus go on forever.

Both Heaven and Earth endure a long time. The cause of their endurance is their indifference to long life. This is why they subsist.

The universe is deathless, is deathless because, having no finite self, it stays infinite.

Heaven and earth will exist forever. The reason they exist forever is that they do not live for themselves and they do not live because of themselves. Therefore they live forever. In the same way, the sage stays behind everything and finds himself in front of everything, he is not himself and he is preserved forever. Since he has no self-interest, his self-interest can realize itself.

Therefore the wise man will keep his personality out of sight and because of so doing he will become notable. He subordinates his personality and therefore it is preserved. Is it not because he is disinterested, that his own interests are conserved? up

The Taoist Master stays behind and is thus ahead. He is detached and is thus one with all things. He is selfless and is thus fulfilled. up

Thus the wise man, indifferent to himself, is the greatest among men, and taking no care for himself, he is nevertheless preserved. By being the most unselfish he is the most secure of all. up

A sound man by not advancing himself stays the further ahead of himself. By not confining himself to himself sustains himself outside himself: By never being an end in himself he endlessly becomes himself.

Even though it looks like heaven and earth give life to all creatures, they do not live in order to preserve their own existence, and therefore they live forever and never die. In his rule over the kingdom, the sage does everything for people, ignoring his personal goals, and ultimately earns glory, honor, and everything he wanted for himself. up

Chapter 8

True goodness is like water, in that it benefits everything and harms nothing. Like water it ever seeks the lowest place, the place that all others avoid. It is closely kin to the Tao. For a dwelling it chooses the quiet meadow; for a heart the circling eddy.	It is good to be like water. It nourishes without effort. It flows without contention into low places that people scorn. Thus, it is like the Tao. In dwelling, live close to the land.	The greatest virtue is like water; it is good to all things. It attains the most inaccessible places without strife. Therefore it is like Tao. It has the virtue of adapting itself to its place. It is virtuous like the heart by being deep.		
In generosity it is kind; in speech it is sincere; in authority it is order; in affairs it is ability; in movement it is rhythm. Inasmuch as it is always peaceable it is never rebuked. up	In thinking, go deep. In relating to others, be gentle. In governing, seek good order and justice. In acting, be skillful. In working, do all things at the right time. No contention, no strife. up	It is virtuous like speech be being faithful. It is virtuous like government in regulating. It is virtuous like a servant in its ability. It is virtuous like action by being in season. And because it does not strive it has no enemies. up		

Chapter 9

Continuing to fill a pail after it is full the water will be wasted. Continuing to grind an axe after it is sharp will soon wear it away. Who can protect a public hall crowded with gold and jewels?

Fill your bowl all the way: it overflows. Keep sharpening your sword: it gets dull. Pile up gold and jade: it cannot be protected.

It is advisable to refrain from continual reaching after wealth. Continual handling and sharpening wears away the most durable thing. If the house be full of jewels, who shall protect it?

Keep stretching a bow You repent of the pull, A 'whetted saw Goes thin and dull, Surrounded with treasure You lie ill at ease, Proud beyond measure You come to your knees: Do enough, without vieing, Be living, not dying.

It is better to leave a thing alone Than to hold it and keep it full to the brim. If you sharpen the blade and use it, It will not remain sharp for long.

The pride of wealth and position brings about their own misfortune. To win true merit, to preserve just fame, the personality must be retiring. This is the heavenly Tao. up

Increase your wealth, status, and power: you suffer ruin. Do your work, then withdraw: that's the Way! up

Wealth and glory bring care along with pride. To stop when good work is done and honour advancing is the way of Heaven. up

When gold and jade fill the temple, No one can protect them. When wealth and honor come together with pride Self-destruction quickly joins them. After the goal has been achieved and the objective has been honorably accomplished, The Tao of heaven Is to retire from everything. up

Chapter 10

WHAT IS POSSIBLE By patience the animal spirits can be disciplined. By self-control one can unify the character. By close attention to the will, compelling gentleness, one can become like a little child. By purifying the subconscious desires one may be without fault. In ruling his country, if the wise magistrate loves his people, he can avoid compulsion.

Can you keep body and soul together and find your wholeness in the One? Can you make your breathing as soft as a newborn child's? Can you cleanse your inner vision until you see with perfect clarity? Can you love the people and govern the country without ado?

By conserving the natural and spiritual powers it is possible to escape dissolution. By restraining the passions and letting gentleness have its sway it is possible to continue as a child. By purging the mind of impurities it is possible to remain untainted. By governing the people with love it is possible to remain unknown.

Can you hold the door of your tent Wide to the firmament? Can you, with the simple stature Of a child, breathing nature, Become, notwithstanding, A man? Can you continue befriending With no prejudice, no ban? Can you, mating with heaven, Serve as the female part?

Can you always keep your soul focused So that nothing can divert it from the Tao? Can you regulate your breathing And be as soft and relaxed as a baby? Can you purify yourself and eliminate the hidden So that you are free of all blemish and error?

In measuring out rewards, the wise magistrate will act like a mother bird. While sharply penetrating into every corner, he may appear to be unsuspecting. While quickening and feeding his people, he will be producing but without pride of ownership. He will benefit but without claim of reward. He will persuade, but not compel by force. This is teh, the profoundest virtue. up

Can you, like a woman, open and close the gates of Heaven? Can you understand all things and take no action? Giving birth and nourishing, having but not owning, acting without seeking praise, leading but not dominating: this is the highest virtue [Te]. up

By continual use of the Gates of Heaven it is possible to preserve them from rust. By transparency on all sides it is possible to remain unrecognized. o bring forth and preserve, to produce without possessing, to act without hope of reward, and to expand without waste, this is the supreme virtue. up

Can your learned head take leaven From the wisdom of your heart? If you can bear issue and nourish its growing, If you can guide without claim or strife, If you can stay in the lead of men without their knowing, You are at the core of life.

Can you love the people and govern the state by non-action? Can you open and close the gates of nature As a woman can? Can you be enlightened and aware And penetrate to the depths of everything, without knowledge? up

Chapter 11

THE VALUE OF NON-EXISTENCE Although the wheel has thirty spokes its utility lies in the emptiness of the hub. The jar is made by kneading clay, but its usefulness consists in its capacity. A room is made by cutting out windows and doors through the walls, but the space the walls contain measures the room's value.	Thirty spokes are joined in the hub of the wheel, but it is the center hole, where it is empty, that makes the wheel useful. We make a clay pot, but it is the emptiness inside that makes the pot useful.	The thirty spokes of a carriage wheel uniting at the nave are made useful by the hole in the centre, where nothing exists. Vessels of moulded earth are useful by reason of their hollowness.	Thirty spokes are made one by holes in a hub, By vacancies joining them for a wheel's use; The use of clay in moulding pitchers Comes from the hollow of its absence; Doors, windows, in a house, Are used for their emptiness: Thus we are helped by what is not To use what is.	Thirty spokes unite in the middle of the wheel, And because of the part between them where nothing exists, We enjoy the use of the carriage wheel. Clay is formed into bowls and vessels, And because of the hollow in it where nothing exists, We use them as vessels. Doors and windows are cut into the walls of the house, And since they are empty space, we can use them.
In the same way matter is necessary to form, but the value of reality lies in its immateriality. (Or thus: a material body is necessary to existence, but the value of a life is measured by its immaterial soul.) up	We cut windows and doors to make a room, but it is the inner emptiness that makes the room useful. We seek to take advantage of what is, but we also find much use for what is not. up	Doors and windows are useful by being cut out. A house is useful because of its emptiness. Existence, therefore, is like unto gain, but Non-Existence to use. up		Therefore, on the one hand, we have the advantage of what exists, And, on the other, we utilize the non-existent. Without that which does not exist, we cannot take advantage of the wheel, the vessel, or the house. Without wooden spokes, clay, and walls, we cannot take advantage of the space they contain. Ultimately, existence and non-existence coexist and are intertwined. up

Chapter 12

AVOIDING
DESIRE An
excess of light
blinds the human
eye; an excess
of noise ruins the
ear; an excess of
condiments
deaden the
taste. The effect
of too much
horse racing and
hunting is bad,
and the lure of
hidden treasure
tempts one to do
evil.

The five colors
can make us
blind. The five
sounds can
make us deaf.
The five flavors
can deaden our
taste. Racing,
chasing, and
hunting can drive
us mad.

Light will blind a
man, sound will
make him deaf,
taste will ruin his
palate, the chase
will make him
wild, and
precious things
will tempt him.

The five colors
can blind, The
five tones
deafen, The five
tastes cloy. The
race, the hunt,
can drive men
mad And their
booty leave them
no peace.

The five colors
blind a person's
sight. The five
sounds deafen a
person's hearing.
The five tastes
dull a person's
palate. Races
and hunting trips
make a person
wild. Things that
are hard to attain
are detrimental
to a person's
conduct.

Therefore the
wise man
attends to the
inner significance
of things and
does not concern
himself with
outward
appearances.
Therefore he
ignores matter
and seeks the
spirit. up

The pursuit of
treasure knocks
us off the path.
Therefore, the
Tao■Master
follows his inner
vision rather than
his outer vision.
He chooses this
but not that. up

Therefore soes
the wise man
provide for the
soul and not for
the senses. He
ignores the one
and takes the
other with both
hands. up

Therefore a
sensible man
Prefers the inner
to the outer eye:
He has his yes,
--he has his no.

For this reason,
the sage
Prepares his
food according to
the size of his
stomach and not
according to the
size of his eyes.
He rejects
surfeit, and opts
for less. up

Chapter 13

LOATHING SHAME Favor and disgrace are alike to be feared, just as too great care or anxiety are bad for the body. Why are favor and disgrace alike to be feared? To be favored is humiliating; to obtain it is as much to be dreaded as to lose it. To lose favor is to be in disgrace and of course is to be dreaded.	Being in favor or being in disgrace: either way, trouble. It is all within the Self. What does this mean? Being in favor, we fear falling out of favor. Being out of favor, we fear remaining there.	Honour and shame are the same as fear. Fortune and disaster are the same as the person. What is said of honour and shame is this: shame is abasement, which is feared whether is be absent or present. So dignity and shame are inseparable from the fear which both occasion.	Favor and disfavor have been called equal worries, Success and failure have been called equal ailments. How can favor and disfavor be called equal worries? Because winning favor burdens a man With the fear of losing it. How can success and failure be called equal ailments? Because a man thinks of the personal body as self.	"Honor and disgrace are like fear. Fortune and disaster are like our body." What does "Honor and disgrace are like fear" mean? Honor is located in a high place, and disgrace is located in a low place. When you have them, it is as if you are in a state of fear, and when you no longer have them, it is also as if you are in a state of fear. Therefore, honor and disgrace are like fear.
Why are excessive care and great anxiety alike bad for one? The very reason I have anxiety is because I have a body. If I have not body why would I be anxious? Therefore if he who administers the empire, esteems it as his own body, then he is worthy to be trusted with the empire. up	This fear is within the Self. No Self, no fear. Do you value the world as you value yourself? You may be trusted to rule. Do you love the world as you love yourself? The world may be entrusted to your care. up	What is said of fortune and disaster is this: fortune and disaster are things which befall the person. So without personality how should I suffer disaster or the reverse? Therefore by the accident of good fortune a man may rule the world for a time. But by virtue of love he may rule the world for ever. up	When he no longer thinks of the personal body as self Neither failure nor success can ail him. One who knows his lot to be the lot of all other men Is a safe man to guide them, One who recognizes all men as members of his own body Is a sound man to guard them.	What does "Fortune and disaster are like our body" mean? We have fortune and disaster because we have a body. When we do not have a body, how can fortune and disaster affect us? Therefore, the person who relates to the world like he relates to the good fortune of his body can rule the world. The world can be safely entrusted to the person who loves it like he loves his body. up

Chapter 14

IN PRAISE OF
THE PROFOUND
It is unseen
because it is
colorless; it is
unheard because
it is soundless;
when seeking to
grasp it, it eludes
one, because it is
incorporeal.
Because of these
qualities it cannot
be examined, and
yet they form an
essential unity.
Superficially it
appears abstruse,
but in its depths it
is not obscure. It
has been
nameless forever!
It appears and
then disappears.

Look, but you
can't see it.
Listen, but you
can't hear it.
Reach out, but
you can't touch it.
Invisible,
inaudible,
intangible.
Elusive. The
One. When it
rises, no light.
When it sets, no
darkness.

le. Plainness is
that which cannot
be seen by looking
at it. He. Stillness
is that which
cannot be heard
by listening to it.
We. Rareness is
that which cannot
be felt by handling
it. These, being
indiscernible, may
be regarded as an
unity - I H W, Tao.
It is not bright
above nor dark
beneath.

What we look for
beyond seeing
And call the
unseen, Listen for
beyond hearing
And call the
unheard, Grasp for
beyond reaching
And call the
withheld, Merge
beyond
understanding In a
oneness Which
does not merely
rise and give light,
Does not merely
set and leave
darkness, But
forever sends forth
a succession of
living things as
mysterious As the
unbegotten
existence to which
they return.

What we look at
and do not see is
called simplicity.
What we listen to
and do not hear is
called rarity. What
we clasp and do
not catch is called
delicateness.
These three
cannot be
discerned, So they
unite to become
one. When it is
revealed, it does
not dazzle, When
it is concealed, it is
not dark, When it
is infinite, it is not
defined. It attains
the non-existent.

It is what is known
as the form of the
formless, the
image of the
imageless. It is
called the
transcendental, its
face (or destiny)
cannot be seen in
front, or its back
(or origin) behind.
But by holding fast
to the Tao of the
ancients, the wise
man may
understand the
present, because
he knows the
origin of the past.
This is the clue to
the Tao. up

It calls all things
back into
nothingness [No
■Thing■Ness].
Formless form,
imageless
image. No front,
no back. Live in
the Tao of old,
master the
present. Know
the Source: The
essence of Tao.
up

Infinite in
operation, it is yet
without name.
Issuing forth it
enters into Itself.
This is the
appearance of the
Non-Apparent, the
form of the
Non-Existent. This
is the
unfathomable
mystery. Going
before, its face is
not seen; following
after, its back is
not observed. Yet
to regulate one's
life by the ancient
knowledge of Tao
is to have found
the path. up

That is why men
have called them
empty
phenomena,
Meaningless
images, In a
mirage With no
face to meet, No
back to follow. Yet
one who is
anciently aware of
existence Is
master of every
moment, Feels no
break since time
beyond time In the
way life flows.

Its name is the
form of the
formless And its
image is that
which does not
have an image. It
is mysterious.
Meet it, and you
will not be able to
see its face,
Follow it, and you
will not be able to
see its back. By
adhering to the
ancient Tao, You
will be master of
the essence of the
present And you
will be aware of
the origin of the
past. That is the
clue to the Tao. up

Chapter 15

The ancient wise men were skilful in their mysterious acquaintance with profundities. They were fathomless in their depths; so profound, that I cannot bring them forth to my mind. They were cautious, like one who crosses a swollen river. They were reserved, like one who doubts his fellows. They were watchful, like one who travels abroad. They were retiring, like snow beneath the sun. They were simple, like newly felled timber.

We must wait for the water to settle; then it will be clear. Can you keep still until what is needed becomes clear? Those who follow the Tao are not full of themselves. They are like durable garments that need no renewal. up

They were lowly, like the valley. They were obscure, like muddy water. May not a man take muddy water and make it clear by keeping still? May not a man take a dead thing and make it alive by continuous motion? Those who follow this Tao have no need of replenishing, and being devoid of all properties, they grow old without need of being filled. up

Because when a man is in turmoil how shall he find peace Save by staying patient till the stream clears? How can a man's life keep its course If he will not let it flow? Those who flow as life flows know They need no other force: They feel no wear, they feel no tear, They need no mending, no repair.

Chapter 16

RETURNING TO THE SOURCE Seek to attain an open mind (the summit of vacuity). Seek composure (the essence of tranquillity). All things are in process, rising and returning. Plants come to blossom, but only to return to the root. Returning to the root is like seeking tranquillity; it is moving towards its destiny.	Empty yourself. Be calm. The ten thousand things come and go. Just watch them. All things return to the Source, where there is stillness. To return to the Source is to recover what is permanent. Knowing what is permanent: enlightenment. Not knowing what is permanent: disaster.	Having emptied yourself of everything, remain where you are. All things spring forth into activity with one accord, and wither do we see them return? After blossoming for a while, everything dies down to its root. This going back to one's origin is called peace: it is the giving of oneself over to the inevitable. This giving of oneself over to the inevitable is called preservation.		Devote yourself to the goal of achieving absolute serenity, Aspire to a state of perfect peace. All things come into existence, And we see them return. Look at the things that bloomed and flowered, Each of them returns to its source. The return to the source is called serenity, Which means following destiny, Following destiny is eternal, it is eternity. He who knows eternity is enlightened.
To move toward destiny is like eternity. To know eternity is enlightenment, and not to recognize eternity brings disorder and evil. Knowing eternity makes one comprehensive; comprehension makes one broadminded; breadth of vision brings nobility; nobility is like heaven. The heavenly is like Tao. Tao is the Eternal. The decay of the body is not to be feared. up	Knowing what is permanent opens the mind. Open mind, open heart. Open heart, magnanimity. Magnanimity, a virtue of queens and kings. A true queen or king lives in accord with Nature. To live in accord with Nature is to find the Tao. Following the Tao makes death harmless. up	He who knows this preservation is called enlightened. He who knows it not continues in misery. He who knows this preservation is great of soul. He who is great of soul is prevailing. Prevailing, he is a king. Being a king, he is celestial. Being celestial, he is of Tao. Being of Tao, he endures for ever: for though his body perish, yet he suffers no hurt. up	He who is open-eyed is open-minded- He who is open-minded is open-hearted, He who is open-hearted is kingly, He who is kingly is godly, He who is godly is useful, He who is useful is infinite, He who is infinite is immune, He who is immune is immortal.	

Chapter 17

SIMPLICITY OF HABIT When great men rule, subjects know little of their existence. Rulers who are less great win the affection and praise of their subjects. A common ruler is feared by his subjects, and an unworthy ruler is despised.	The best ruler: hardly known to exist. Next best: known and loved. Next best: feared. The worst: despised.	In the first age of mankind the people recognized their superiors. In the second age they served and flattered them. In the third age they feared them, In the fourth age they despised them.	A leader is best When people barely know that he exists, Not so good when people obey and acclaim him, Worst when they despise him.	The greatest rulers are the ones whose existence the people do not notice at all, The rulers who are inferior to them are the ones whom the people honor and praise, And inferior to those are the ones of whom they are afraid, And inferior to those are the ones whom they despise.
When a ruler lacks faith, you may seek in vain for it among his subjects. How carefully a wise ruler chooses his words. He performs deeds, and accumulates merit! Under such a ruler the people think they are ruling themselves. up	No trust given, no trust received. The best ruler rules without fanfare. When his work is successful, the people say, "Fantastic! We've done it!" up	Where faith is lacking it does not inspire confidence. How careful were they in their expressions! When they had done a good thing they would say, "How very natural we are!" up	'Fail to honor people, They fail to honor you;' But of a good leader, who talks little, When his work is done, his aim fulfilled, They will all say, 'We did this ourselves.'	When there is a lack of faith in the ruler, No one believes in his rule. Now, learn how much importance must be attributed to words. up

Chapter 18

THE PALLIATION OF THE INFERIOR When the great Tao is lost sight of, we still have the idea of benevolence and righteousness. Prudence and wisdom come to mind when we see great hypocrisy.	When the Tao is not followed, kindness and morality appear. When intelligence and learning are exalted, pretentiousness emerges.	When the great Tao is lost men follow after charity and duty to one's neighbours. When wisdom has met with honours the world is full of pretenders.	When people lost sight of the way to live Came codes of love and honesty, Learning came, charity came, Hypocrisy took charge; When differences weakened family ties Came benevolent fathers and dutiful sons; And when lands were disrupted and misgoverned Came ministers commended as loyal.	When the great Tao is lost, justice, righteousness and good will spring forth. When wisdom and cunning emerge, hypocrisy raises its head. When family ties are no longer harmonious, honoring parents and caring for children still remain.
When relatives are! unfriendly, we still have the teachings of filial piety and paternal affection. When the state and the clan are in confusion and disorder, we still have the ideals of loyalty and faithfulness. up	When there is no peace and order in the family, then we get all kinds of talk about "family values." When the country is badly governed and in chaos, we then glorify patriotism. up	When family ties are severed then filial duty and parental indulgence take their place When a nation is filled with strife then do patriots flourish. up		When a nation is in a state of confusion and disorder, patriotism becomes evident. When Tao is present, equilibrium is present. When Tao is lost, the differences between things emerge. up

Chapter 19

RETURN TO SIMPLICITY Abandon the show of saintliness and relinquish excessive prudence, then people will benefit a hundredfold. Abandon ostentatious benevolence and conspicuous righteousness, then people will return to the primal virtues of filial piety and parental affection.	Discard learning and knowledge, and the people will be a hundred times happier. Banish kindness and morality, and the people will rediscover love and duty.	By giving up their self-righteousness and abandoning their wisdom the people would be immensely improved. Forsaking Charity and Duty to the neighbours, they might revert to their natural relations. Abandoning excellence and foregoing gain, the people would have no more thieves.	Rid of formalized wisdom and learning People would be a hundredfold happier, Rid of conventionalized duty and honor People would find their families dear, Rid of legalized profiteering People would have no thieves to fear.	Abandon learning, And grief and sorrow will no longer be known. Abandon learned volumes, cast off wisdom, And people will be one hundred times better off. Abandon righteousness, cast off justice, And people will return to filial duty and birthing offspring.
Abandon cleverness and relinquish gains, then thieves and robbers will disappear. Here are three fundamentals on which to depend, wherein culture is insufficient. Therefore let all men hold to that which is reliable, namely, recognize simplicity, cherish purity, reduce one's possessions, diminish one's desires. up	Forget about industry and profit, and there won't be any thieves. When these three things are done, more will be required: Look at plain silk; hold uncarved wood; let self dwindle; let desire fade. up	The cultivation of these things has been a failure, therefore they should go back whence they came. And for you, do come forth in your natural simplicity, lay hold on verities, restrain selfishness, and rid yourself of ambition. up	These methods of life have failed, all three, Here is the way, it seems to me: Set people free, As deep in their hearts they would like to be, From private greeds And wanton needs.	Abandon cunning, cast off avarice, And bandits and thieves will disappear from the earth. These four principles, even if they form the foundation of human culture, are not sufficient. Therefore, here are principles to which people can adhere: Show integrity, adhere to simplicity, Restrain selfishness, curtail lusts. up

Chapter 20

THE OPPOSITE OF THE COMMONPLACE Avoid learning if you would have no anxiety. The "yes" and the "yea" differ very little, but the contrast between good and evil is very great. That which is not feared by the people is not worth fearing. But, oh, the difference, the desolation, the vastness, between ignorance and the limitless expression of the Tao.	No more learning, no more trouble. Is there any real difference between "Ahhh!" and "Yuk!"? What about "good" and "evil"? Must I fear what others fear? Ridiculous! Everybody else is smiling, having fun as if at a festival or carnival. I alone am drifting, not knowing whether I'm coming or going, like a baby before it has learned to smile.			
(The balance of this sonnet is devoted to showing the difference between the careless state of the common people and his own vision of the Tao. It is one of the most pathetic expressions of human loneliness, from lack of appreciation, ever written. It is omitted here that it might serve for the closing sonnet and valedictory.) up	Others have what they need; I have nothing. I might as well be homeless. I'm a fool. Very confused. Others are bright; I am dim. Others are sharp; I am dull, lost at sea, without direction. Others have plans; I am aimless. I am different from others. I am nourished by the Great Mother. up		Men of the world have a surplus of goods, While I am left out, owning nothing. What a booby I must be Not to know my way round, What a fool! The average man is so crisp and so confident That I ought to be miserable Going on and on like the sea, Drifting nowhere. All these people are making their mark in the world, While I, pig-headed, awkward, Different from the rest, Am only a glorious infant still nursing at the breast.	

Chapter 21

THE HEART OF
EMPTINESS All
the innumerable
forms of teh
correspond to the
norm of Tao, but
the nature of the
Tao's activity is
infinitely abstract
and illusive.
Illusive and
obscure, indeed,
but at its heart are
forms and types.
Vague and illusive,
indeed, but at its
heart is all being.

Te flows from
Tao. Tao is
elusive and
evasive. Evasive
and elusive, yet
within it there are
ideas. Elusive
and evasive, yet
within it are
entities. Dark
and obscure, yet
within it there is
life.

The greatest
virtue is in simply
following Tao,
the intangible,
inscrutable.
Inscrutable,
intangible, and
yet containing
forms. Intangible,
inscrutable, and
yet containing
things. Profound
and obscure, but
having an
essence, a
veritable
essence in which
is consistence.

The surest test if
a man be sane Is
if he accepts life
whole, as it is,
Without needing
by measure or
touch to
understand The
measureless
untouchable
source Of its
images, The
measureless
untouchable
source Of its
substances, The

The
manifestation of
the great virtue is
to follow the way
of the Tao. Tao is
a thing that is
invisible,
inaccessible.
Inaccessible,
invisible, and yet
it has image and
form. Cloudy and
obscure, but
there is essence
in it, And this
essence is
absolute truth,
and there is
belief in it.

Unfathomable and
obscure, indeed,
but at its heart is
all spirit, and spirit
is reality. At its
heart is truth. From
of old its
expression is
unceasing, it has
been present at all
beginnings. How
do I know that its
nature is thus? By
this same Tao. up

The life of the
Tao is so real; it
gives rise to
certainty. From
the beginning
until now, it has
appeared in
countless forms,
it has been given
countless
names. How do I
know this? Like
this! up

From eternity
until now its
nature has
remained
unchanged. It
inheres in all
things from their
beginnings. How
do I know of the
origin of things? I
know by Tao. up

source which,
while it appears
dark emptiness,
Brims with a
quick force
Farthest away
And yet nearest
at hand From
oldest time unto
this day,
Charging its
images with
origin: What
more need I
know of the
origin Than this?

From ancient
times until now, it
has not lost its
nameless name,
Through it the
source of all
things has
passed. How do I
know that the
source of all
things is in it?
From the Tao. up

Chapter 22

INCREASE BY HUMILITY At that time the deficient will be made perfect; the distorted will be straightened; the empty will be filled; the worn out will be renewed; those having little will obtain and those having much will be overcome. Therefore the wise man, embracing unity as he does, will become the world's model.

To be whole, let yourself break. To be straight, let yourself bend. To be full, let yourself be empty. To be new, let yourself wear out. To have everything, give everything up. The Taoist Master clings to the Tao and becomes a model for all. He doesn't put on a show, but his light shines forth.

'Yield and you need not break:' Bent you can straighten, Emptied you can hold, Torn you can mend; And as want can reward you So wealth can bewilder.

Be modest, and you will remain whole. Be bent, and you will remain straight. Be empty, and you will remain full. Be worn out, and you will remain new. The one who has little will receive. The one who has a lot will be enslaved. Therefore the sage guards the one, And becomes a paradigm for the world. He does not expose himself, therefore he shines.

Not pushing himself forward he will become enlightened; not asserting himself he will become distinguished; not boasting of himself he will acquire merit; not approving himself he will endure. Forasmuch as he will not quarrel, the world will not quarrel with him. Is the old saying, "The crooked shall be made straight," a false saying? Indeed, no! They will be perfected and return rejoicing. up

He doesn't justify himself, but he is known for his integrity. He doesn't boast, but he is recognized as accomplished. He doesn't contend with others, and thus no one contends with him. The old saying, "Surrender and conquer," is not an empty slogan. Surrender to the Tao and find yourself completed. up

He is not egotistic, and therefore he is praised. He is not vain, therefore he is esteemed. He is not haughty, and therefore he is honoured. And because he does not compete with others, no man is his enemy. The ancient maxim, "Whosoever adapteth himself shall be preserved to the end," verily it is no idle saying. Without doubt he shall go back to his Home in peace. up

Aware of this, a wise man has the simple return Which other men seek: Without inflaming himself He is kindled, Without explaining himself Is explained, Without taking credit Is accredited, Laying no claim Is acclaimed And, because he does not compete, Finds peaceful competence. How true is the old saying, 'Yield and you need not break!' How completely it comes home!

He does not make a good name for himself, therefore he is known. He does not praise himself, therefore he is dear to everyone. He does not glorify himself, therefore his name is on everyone's lips. And since he does not compete at all, There is no one in the world who can compete with him. The ancient ones said: Be modest, and you will remain whole. Can these be meaningless words? Indeed, he will return home whole. up

Chapter 23

EMPTINESS AND NOT-DOING (WU WEI) Taciturnity is natural to man. A whirlwind never outlasts the morning, nor a violent rain the day. What is the cause? It is heaven and earth. If even heaven and earth are not constant, much less can man be. Therefore he who pursues his affairs in the spirit of Tao will become Tao-like.

Much talk is contrary to nature. The wind doesn't blow all morning. The rain doesn't fall all day. Wind and rain are caused by nature, If nature restrains herself, shouldn't people do the same? He who follows the Tao is one with the Tao.

Moderate your speech, and preserve yourself. A hurricane will not outlast the morning, a heavy rain will not outlast the day. Who have the power to make these things but Heaven and Earth? And if Heaven and Earth cannot continue them long, how shall a man do so? If a man accords with Tao in all things, he is identified with Tao by that agreement.

Nature does not have to insist, Can blow for only half a morning, Rain for only half a day, And what are these winds and these rains but natural? If nature does not have to insist, Why should man?

It is natural to be frugal with words. A gale will not blow for an entire morning; Pelting rain will not fall for a whole day. Who causes all those? Heaven and earth. If (the fruit of) heaven and earth cannot last forever, How can man? The person who follows the Tao, Is identified with the Tao.

He who pursues his affairs with teh, will become teh-like. He who pursues his affairs with loss, identifies himself with loss. He who identifies himself with Tao, Tao rejoices to guide. He who identifies himself with teh, teh rejoices to reward. And he who identifies himself with loss, loss rejoices to ruin. If his faith fail, he will receive no reward of faith. up

He who is virtuous is one with Virtue [Te]. He who loses the Tao becomes a loss. Surrender to the Tao, and it will be your home. Practice virtue [Te], and it will be your abode. Lose the Tao, and you will then reside in loss. No trust given, no trust received. up

A virtuous man is identified with virtue, a vicious man is identified with vice. Whoever is identified with Tao, him do the Taoists receive with gladness. Whoever is identified with virtue, him do the virtuous receive with gladness. But whoever is identified with vice, him do the vicious gladly serve with vice. For wherever confidence is lacking, it is not met with trust. up

It is natural too That whoever follows the way of life feels alive, That whoever uses it properly feels well used, Whereas he who loses the way of life feels lost, That whoever keeps to the way of life Feels at home, Whoever uses it properly Feels welcome, Whereas he who uses it improperly Feels improperly used: 'Fail to honor people, They fail to honor you.

The person who adheres to virtue, Is identified with virtue. The person who adheres to vice, Is identified with vice. When a person follows the Tao, The Tao looks kindly upon him. When the person adheres to virtue, Virtue welcomes him. When the person adheres to vice, Vice opens its door to him. up

Chapter 24

TROUBLES AND MERIT It is not natural to stand on tiptoe, or being astride one does not walk. One who displays himself is not bright, or one who asserts himself cannot shine. A self-approving man has no merit, nor does one who praises himself grow.

He who stands on tiptoe does not stand firm. He who walks fast cannot walk far. He who shows off does not shine forth. He who pushes will not succeed.

By standing on tiptoe one cannot keep still. Astride of one's fellow one cannot progress. By displaying oneself one does not shine. By self-approbation one is not esteemed. In self-praise there is no merit.

Standing tiptoe a man loses balance, Walking astride he has no pace, Kindling himself he fails to light, Acquitting himself he forfeits his hearers, Admiring himself he does so alone.

A person who stands on tiptoe cannot stand firmly on his feet. A person who spreads his legs cannot walk steadily. A person who displays himself cannot shine (like a star in the sky). A person who praises himself will not be praised by others. A person who glorifies himself will not be famous.

The relation of these things (self-display, self-assertion, self-approval) to Tao is the same as offal is to food. They are excrescences from the system; they are detestable; Tao does not dwell in them. up

He who boasts will not achieve. He who praises his own work creates nothing that endures. These things inspire disgust. Followers of the Tao spurn them. up

He who exalts himself does not stand high. Such things are to Tao what refuse and excreta are to the body. They are everywhere detested. Therefore the man of Tao will not abide with them. up

Pride has never brought a man greatness But, according to the way of life, Brings the ills that make him unfit, Make him unclean in the eyes of his neighbor, And a sane man will have none of them.

A person who makes himself mighty cannot excel. All these, in comparison to the Tao, are called: "A surfeit of food and an excess of action." They will be tiresome to everyone in other things, too. Therefore, the man of Tao is not found in their company. All these are examples of living in a way that goes against nature. up

Chapter 25

DESCRIBING THE MYSTERIOUS

There is Being that is all-inclusive and that existed before Heaven and Earth. Calm, indeed, and incorporeal! It is alone and changeless! Everywhere it functions unhindered. It thereby becomes the world's mother. I do not know its nature; if I try to characterize it, I will call it Tao. If forced to give it a name, I will call it the Great.

Before the birth of Heaven and Earth, there was something without form but complete. Silent. Empty. Independent. Unchanging. Infinite. Eternal. It is the Mother of all things. I cannot classify it, but I call it Tao.

Before Heaven and Earth existed there was in Nature a primordial substance. It was serene, it was fathomless. It was self-existent, it was homogeneous. It was omnipresent, nor suffered any limitation. It is to be regarded as the universal mother. I do not know its name, but I call it Tao. If forced to qualify it, I call it the boundless. Being boundless, I call it the inconceivable.

The Great is evasive, the evasive is the distant, the distant is ever coming near. Tao is Great. So is Heaven great, and so is Earth and so also is the representative of Heaven and Earth. Man is derived from nature, nature is derived from Heaven, Heaven is derived from Tao. Tao is self-derived. up

Powerful, it creates all things, is present in all things, returns all things to their origin. The Tao is great. Heaven is great. Earth is great. Humanity is great. These are the four great things. Humanity follows Earth. Earth follows Heaven. Heaven follows Tao. Tao follows its own nature. up

Being inscrutable, I call it the inaccessible. Being inaccessible, I call it the omnipresent. Tao is supreme, Heaven is supreme, Earth is supreme, the King is supreme. There are in the universe four kinds of supremacy, and their rulership is one. Man is ruled by the Earth, the Earth is ruled by Heaven, Heaven is ruled by Tao, and Tao is ruled by itself. up

In this sense The way of life is fulfilled, Heaven is fulfilled, Earth fulfilled And a fit man also is fulfilled: These are the four amplitudes of the universe And a fit man is one of them: Man rounding the way of earth, Earth rounding the way of heaven, Heaven rounding the way of life Till the circle is full.

Therefore Tao is "all-embracing," Heaven is "all-embracing," Earth is "all-embracing," Man is "all-embracing." In the universe, four things are "all-embracing," And man is one of them. Man adheres to the laws of earth, Earth adheres to the laws of heaven, Heaven adheres to the laws of Tao, Tao adheres to the laws of its nature. up

Chapter 26

THE VIRTUE
(TEH) OF
DIGNITY The
heavy is the root of
the light; the quiet
is master of
motion. Therefore
the wise man in all
the experience of
the day will not
depart from
dignity. Though he
be surrounded
with sights that are
magnificent, he will
remain calm and
unconcerned.

Heavy is the
foundation of
light. Stillness is
the source of
movement. Thus,
the Taoist Master
travels all day
without losing
sight of the
baggage cart. He
is not swept
away by splendid
scenery. He
remains quiet
and unperturbed.

Weight underlies
lightness,
quiescence
underlies motion.
Therefore the
Sage never loses
his gravity and
quiescence from
day to day.
Though glorious
palaces should
belong to him, he
would dwell in
them peacefully,
without
attachment.

Gravity is the
root of grace,
The mainstay of
all speed. A
traveler of true
means, whatever
the day's pace,
Remembers the
provision-van
And, however
fine prospect be
offered, is a man
With a calm
head.

Heaviness is the
basis of lightness,
The passing is the
basis of
movement,
Therefore the
sage, even when
traveling all day
long, Never
abandons the
baggage wagon,
Therefore the
sage, even when
surrounded by
splendor and
luxury, Is shrouded
in indifference that
stems from
serenity. How can
this great emperor,
with a thousand
chariots, Move
easily throughout
his kingdom?

How does it come
to pass that the
Emperor, master
of ten thousand
chariots, has lost
the mastery of the
Empire? Because
being flippant
himself, he has
lost the respect of
his subjects; being
passionate
himself, he has
lost the control of
the Empire. up

Why should the
lord of the land
allow himself to
be swept away?
Allow yourself to
be swept away,
and you lose
your foundation.
Allow yourself to
be moved, and
you lose
self-mastery. up

Alas that a king
with many
chariots should
conduct himself
with frivolity in
the midst of his
kingdom! By
levity he loses
his ministers,
and by
inconstancy his
throne. up

What lord of
countless
chariots would
ride them in vain,
Would make
himself fool of
the realm, With
pace beyond
rein, Speed
beyond helm?

If he is light, he will
lose his basis, If
he is hasty, he will
lose his serenity.
Wang-Pi
comments: The
light cannot bear
the heavy; the
small cannot
contain the large;
the sedentary
controls the
moving, the one
who does not
move from his
place controls the
one who moves
from his place.
Therefore
heaviness is the
basis of lightness,
and serenity is the
secret of control.
up

Chapter 27

THE FUNCTION OF SKILL Good walkers leave no tracks, good speakers make no errors, good counters need no abacus, good wardens have no need for bolts and locks for no one can get by them. Good binders can dispense with rope and cord, yet none can unloose their hold. Therefore the wise man trusting in goodness always saves men, for there is no outcast to him.

Following the Tao, the Tao■Master leaves no tracks, speaks without error, counts without markers. No locks on his door, and yet no one can open it. No rope used, and yet his knots cannot be untied. Thus, the Tao■Master cares for all beings and neglects none.

A good walker makes no dust after him. The good speaker incurs no discussion. The good reckoner needs no arithmetic. The good keeper needs no bolts or bars, and none can open after him. The wise man is constant and a good helper of his fellows. He rejects none. He is a continual good preserver of things.

One may move so well that a foot-print never shows, Speak so well that the tongue never slips, Reckon so well that no counter is needed, Seal an entrance so tight, though using no lock, That it cannot be opened, Bind a hold so firm, though using no cord, That it cannot be untied. And these are traits not only of a sound man But of many a man thought to be unsound.

Trusting in goodness he saves all things for there is nothing valueless to him. This is recognizing concealed values. Therefore the good man is the instructor of the evil man, and the evil man is the good man's wealth. He who does not esteem his instructors or value his wealth, though he be otherwise intelligent, becomes confused. Herein lies the significance of spirituality. up

Thus, he follows the light. The Tao■Master teaches the fool; and thus the fool learns. But teaching and learning will not take place unless the student values the teacher and the teacher loves the student. This is the subtle secret of teaching and learning. up

He disdains nothing. His intelligence is all-embracing. Good men instruct one another; and bad men are the material they delve in. Whoever, therefore, does not honour his teacher and cherish his material, though he be called wise, is yet in a state of delusion. This is no less important than strange. up

A sound man is good at salvage, At seeing that nothing is lost. Having what is called insight, A good man, before he can help a bad man, Finds in himself the matter with the bad man. And whichever teacher Discounts the lesson Is as far off the road as the other, Whatever else he may know. That is the heart of it.

He is good to all creatures, He spurns nothing. This state is called "to see and to come to the light." Therefore, good people are guides to bad people, And many people are like matter in good people's hands. And the person who does not appreciate his guide, And the person who does not love the matter in his hand, All their success comes from blindness. This is the main principle of the secret. up

Chapter 28

Know the male, maintain the female: become the channel of all things. Become the channel of all things, and true power [Te] will endure. You will be reborn. Know the white, maintain the black: become the form of all things. Become the form of all things, and true power [Te] will endure.

He who, being a man, remains a woman, will become an universal channel. As an universal channel the eternal virtue will never forsake him. He will re-become a child. He who, being in the light, remains in obscurity, will become an universal model. As an universal model the eternal virtue will not pass him by. He will go back to the all-perfect.

He who knows the glory of his nature and recognizes also his limitations becomes useful like the world's valleys. Being like the world's valleys, eternal teh will not fail him, he will revert to simplicity. Radiating simplicity he will make of men vessels of usefulness. The wise man then will employ them as officials and chiefs. A great administration of such will harm no one. up

You will return to the Infinite. Know honor, maintain humility: become the valley of all things. Become the valley of all things, and true power [Te] will endure. You will find the simplicity of nature. Uncarved wood, when carved by the Tao■Master, becomes a well■governed state. The best carving is that which is not carved at all. up

being a valley of the world, Continuously, endlessly Conducts the one source From which vessels may be usefully filled; Servants of the state are such vessels, To be filled from undiminishing supply.

Chapter 29

NOT FORCING THINGS (WU WEI) One who desires to take and remake the Empire will fail. The Empire is a divine thing that cannot be remade. He who attempts it will only mar it.

Do you think you can control the world? I don't think so. The world belongs to the Tao. It can't be controlled. If you mess with it, you'll ruin it. If you try to grab it, you'll lose it.

When a man who wishes to reform the world takes it in hand, I perceive that there will be no end to it! Spiritual vessels are not fashioned in the world. Whoever makes destroys; whoever grasps loses.

Those who would take over the earth And shape it to their will Never, I notice, succeed. The earth is like a vessel so sacred That at the mere approach of the profane It is marred And when they reach out their fingers it is gone.

When a person undertakes to hold and mold the world, I see that he will fail in this task. Since the world is an instrument of God: It cannot be molded, It cannot be held. He who tries to mold it damages it, He who insists on holding it loses it.

He who seeks to grasp it, will lose it. People differ, some lead, others follow; some are ardent, others are formal; some are strong, others weak; some succeed, others fail. Therefore the wise man practices moderation; he abandons pleasure, extravagance and indulgence. up

Some things move on; others remain behind; some things are hot; others are cold; some things are strong; others are weak; some things are up; others are down. The Tao■Master renounces extremes, excess, and extravagance. up

For perforce if one advances another is left behind; if one blows hot another will blow cold; if one be strengthened another will be weakened; is one be supported another will be undermined. Therefore the Sage gives up all enthusiasm, levity, and pomp. up

For a time in the world some force themselves ahead And some are left behind, For a time in the world some make a great noise And some are held silent, For a time in the world some are puffed fat And some are kept hungry, For a time in the world some push aboard And some are tipped out: At no time in the world will a man who is sane Over-reach himself, Over-spend himself, Over-rate himself.

Therefore the sage does not mold it, and therefore he does not damage it, He does not try to hold it, and therefore he does not lose it. With all things, some move forward while others lag behind, Some hold their tongues, while others speak a lot, Some are strong, while others are weak, Some are on the wagon, while others fall off. Therefore the sage avoids excess, extremism, haughtiness, lust, and arrogance. up

Chapter 30

BE STINGY OF WAR When the magistrate follows Tao, he has no need to resort to force of arms to strengthen the Empire, because his business methods alone will show good returns. Briars and thorns grow rank where an army camps. Bad harvests are the sequence of a great war. The good ruler will be resolute and then stop, he dare not take by force.

How to govern in accordance with the Tao: No conquest by force of arms. Weapons always turn back against themselves. Encamp an army today; the campground is all thorns and brambles tomorrow. Make war for a month; there will be famine for years.

The man who aids the King by use of Tao forces the people into submission without resort to the use of arms. He will not regard the fruit of his actions. Prickly briars and thorns flourish where battalions have quartered. Bad years follow on the heels of armies in motion. The good soldier is brave when occasion requires, but he does not risk himself for power.

One who would guide a leader of men in the uses of life Will warn him against the use of arms for conquest. Weapons often turn upon the wielder, An army's harvest is a waste of thorns, Conscription of a multitude of men Drains the next year dry. A good general, daring to march, dares also to halt, Will never press his triumph beyond need.

The person who helps a ruler of men with the Tao Does not force the world with weapons. He aims only to redeem the Tao, And does not attempt to force his strength on others. Bringing redemption, he does not attribute it to himself, He does not boast much, he is not proud, He thinks that it is his obligation to do so.

One should be resolute but not boastful; resolute but not haughty; resolute but not arrogant; resolute but yielding when it cannot be avoided; resolute but he must not resort to violence. By a resort to force, things flourish for a time but then decay. This is not like the Tao and that which is not Tao-like will soon cease. up

Do what needs to be done, but do not rejoice in victory. Make war, if necessary, and win, but without arrogance, without hostility, without pride, without needless violence. War, victory, and the rest do not last. They are contrary to Tao. What is contrary to Tao perishes quickly. up

Brave is he when occasion requires, but he does not oppress. Brave is he when occasion requires, but he does not boast. Brave is he when occasion requires, but he is not mean. Brave is he when occasion requires, but he does not rage. Things become old through excess of vigour. This is called Non-Tao; and what is Non-Tao is soon wasted! up

What he must do he does but not for glory, What he must do he does but not for show, What he must do he does but not for self; He has done it because it had to be done, Not from a hot head. Let life ripen and then fall, Force is not the way at all: Deny the way of life and you are dead.

This is how redemption will be, without force. When things reach their full power, They begin their process of aging. This goes against the Tao. Whatever goes against the Tao will quickly come to an end. up

Chapter 31

Weapons generate fear; all creatures hate them. Therefore, the Taoist Master tries not to use them He uses them only when there is no alternative, and then without joy, in a calm and restrained way.

Even the finest arms are an instrument of evil, A spread of plague, And the way for a vital man to go is not the way of a soldier. But in time of war men civilized in peace Turn from their higher to their lower nature. Arms are an instrument of evil, No measure for thoughtful men Until there fail all other choice But sad acceptance of it. Triumph is not beautiful.

Enjoy weapons, enjoy killing. Enjoy killing, lose yourself The killing of many people should create sorrow and grief. A great victory is a funeral ceremony. up

He who thinks triumph beautiful Is one with a will to kill, And one with a will to kill Shall never prevail upon the world. It is a good sign when man's higher nature comes forward, A bad sign when his lower nature comes forward, When retainers take charge And the master stays back As in the conduct of a funeral. The death of a multitude is cause for mourning: Conduct your triumph as a funeral.

Chapter 32

THE VIRTUE (TEH) OF HOLINESS Tao in its eternal aspect is unnamable. Its simplicity appears insignificant, but the whole world cannot control it. If princes and kings employ it every one of themselves will pay willing homage. Heaven and Earth by it are harmoniously combined and drop sweet dew. People will have no need of rulers, because of themselves they will be righteous.

The Tao cannot be named or defined. It is invisible, but it contains all things. If rulers could master it, then everything would fall into place. Heaven and Earth would be united. A sweet rain would fall. People would be just without regulation.

Tao the absolute has no name. But although insignificant in its original simplicity, the world does not presume to bemean it. If a king could lay hold on it, the world would of itself submit to him. Heaven and Earth would conspire to nourish him. The peopole without pressure would peacefully fall into their own places.

Existence is infinite, not to be defined; And, though it seem but a bit of wood in your hand, to carve as you please, It is not to be lightly played with and laid down. When rulers adhered to the way of life, They were upheld by natural loyalty: Heaven and earth were joined and made fertile, Life was a freshness of rain, Subject to none, Free to all.

The Tao was always nameless. When it was expressed for the first time, It was given a name.

As soon as Tao expresses itself in orderly creation then it becomes comprehensible. When one recognizes the presence of Tao he understands where to stop. Knowing where to stop he is free from danger. To illustrate the nature of Tao's place in the universe: Tao is like the brooks and streams in their relation to the great rivers and the ocean. up

However, when people seek to rule, they divide the whole and begin assigning names to things. And now, there are names upon names. Too many! The naming must stop. Knowing when to stop saves us from danger. Tao in the world is like rivers flowing into the sea. up

If he should dispose them by titles and names, he would be making a name for himself. Yet he would wisely stop short of the name, and thus avoid the evil of distinctions. Tao is to the world what the streams and valleys are to the great rivers and seas. up

But men of culture came, with their grades and their distinctions; And as soon as such differences had been devised No one knew where to end them, Though the one who does know the end of all such differences Is the sound man: Existence Might be likened to the course Of many rivers reaching the one sea.

And once it has already been given a name, it is necessary to stop. The knowledge of where to stop makes a person immune to any danger. up

Chapter 33

THE VIRTUE (TEH) OF DISCRIMINATION He who knows others is intelligent; he who understands himself is enlightened; he who is able to conquer others has force, but he who is able to control himself is mighty.	Knowing others is a kind of knowledge; knowing yourself is wisdom. Conquering others requires strength; conquering yourself is true power [Te].	He is wise who knows others. He who knows himself is enlightened. He is strong who conquers others. He who conquers himself is mighty. He is rich who is well satisfied.	Knowledge studies others, Wisdom is self-known; Muscle masters brothers, Self-mastery is bone; Content need never borrow, Ambition wanders blind: Vitality cleaves to the marrow Leaving death behind.	The person who knows others is wise, The person who knows himself is enlightened. The person who conquers others is strong, The person who conquers himself is powerful. The person who knows his lot is rich. The person who maintains his path with energy has a strong will.
He who appreciates contentment is wealthy. He who dares to act has nerve; if he can maintain his position he will endure, but he, who dying does not perish, is immortal. up	To realize that you have enough is true wealth. Pushing ahead may succeed, but staying put brings endurance. Die without perishing, and find the eternal. up	He walks fast who has an object. He who fills his place remains secure. He who dies without being corrupted enjoys a good old age. up		The person who does not stray from his proper place will have a long life. The person who dies but does not perish will exist forever. Feo-tzu says: "The difficulty in knowing is not learning others, but learning ourselves. Therefore, the person who learns himself is enlightened." up

Chapter 34

THE
PERFECTION OF
TRUST Great Tao
is all pervading! It
can be on both the
right hand and the
left. Everything
relies upon it for
their existence,
and it does not fail
them. It acquires
merit but covets
not the title. It
lovingly nourishes
everything, but
does not claim the
rights of
ownership.

The Tao is like
an overflowing
river. It rises to
the left and to the
right. The ten
thousand things
arise from it, but
do not depart
from it. The Tao
acts, but cannot
be defined. It
clothes and
nourishes all
beings, but does
not rule over
them.

Mighty Tao is all
pervading. It is
simultaneously on
this side and on
that. All living
things subsist from
it, and all are in its
care. It works, it
finishes, and
knows not the
name of merit. In
love it nurtures all
things, and claims
no excellence
therein.

Bountiful life,
letting anyone
attend, Making
no distinction
between left or
right. Feeding
everyone,
refusing no one,
Has not provided
this bounty to
show how much
it owns, Has not
fed and clad its
guests with any
thought of claim;
And, because it
lacks the twist Of
mind or body in
what it has done,
The guile of head
or hands, Is not
always respected
by a guest.

The great Tao is
in everything,
both on the left
and on the right.
Through it, all
things come into
being, and it
does not
abandon them.
When its work is
completed, it
does not
possess them. It
loves and
nurtures all
things, But does
not rule them.

It has no desires, it
can be classed
with the small.
Everything returns
to it, yet it does not
claim the right of
ownership. It can
be classed with
the great.
Therefore the wise
man to the end will
not pose as a
great man, and by
so doing will
express his true
greatness. up

It endures
without desire
and without
seeming "big."
The ten
thousand things
find their home in
it, and yet it does
not exercise
lordship over
them. The Tao is
very great, but it
does not show its
greatness.
Therefore, it is
truly great. up

It knows neither
ambition nor
desire. It can be
classed with the
humblest of things.
All things finally
revert to it, and it is
not thereby
increased. It can
be mentioned with
the greatest of
things. Thus does
the wise man
continually refrain
from
self-distinction. up

Others
appreciate
welcome from
the perfect host
Who, barely
appearing to
exist, Exists the
most.

It never exists,
so it can be
called small,
apparently. All
things return
home to it, And it
does not claim to
own them, So it
can be called
great,
apparently. It
never aspires to
greatness, And
therefore it
accomplishes
greatness. up

Chapter 35

THE VIRTUE
(TEH) OF
BENEVOLENCE
The world will go
to him who
grasps this Great
Principle; they
will seek and not
be injured, they
will find
contentment,
peace and rest.
Music and
dainties attract
the passing
people, while
Tao's reality
seen-is insipid.

Kapitel nicht
vorhanden /

Attain to the
Great Idea, and
all the world will
flock to you. It
will flock to you
and will not be
hurt therein, for it
will rest in a
wonderful peace.
Where there is a
festival the
wayfarer will
stay.

If the sign of life
is in your face He
who responds to
it Will feel secure
and fit As when,
in a friendly
place, Sure of
hearty care, A
traveler gladly
waits.

The person who
holds the great
thing Will go
through a whole
world. He will go
along the path
straightforwardly
without seeing
danger, But finds
tranquillity,
friendship, and
equality. The
sounds of a tune
and the scent of
delicacies will
cause the
stranger passing
by to stop.

Indeed it has no
taste, when
looked at there is
not enough seen
to be prized,
when listened
for, it can
scarcely be
heard, but, the
use of it is
inexhaustible. up

chapter not
available up

To the palate the
Tao is insipid
and tasteless. In
regarding it the
eye is not
impressed. In
listening to it the
ear is not filled.
But in its uses it
is inexhaustible.
up

Though it may
not taste like
food And he may
not see the fare
Or hear a sound
of plates, How
endless it is and
how good!

But Tao, when it
is expressed in
words, is pure,
devoid of all
taste. When
someone looks
at it, he won't see
it. When
someone listens
to it, he won't
hear it. However,
when someone
uses it, it is
everything. up

Chapter 36

EXPLANATION
OF A PARADOX
That which has a
tendency to
contract must first
have been
extended; that
which has a
tendency to
weaken itself must
first have been
strong; that which
shows a tendency
to destroy itself
must first have
been raised up;
that which shows a
tendency to scatter
must first have
been gathered.

To shrink, you
must first
expand. To
weaken, you
must first
strengthen. To
knock down, you
must first raise
up. To receive,
you must first
give.

When Nature is
about to withhold
a thing it is sure
first to increase
it. When about to
weaken it is first
sure to
strengthen.
When about to
debase it is
certain first to
exalt. When
about to deprive
it is first sure to
give.

He who feels
punctured Must
once have been
a bubble, He
who feels
unarmed Must
have carried
arms, He who
feels belittled
Must have been
consequential,
He who feels
deprived Must
have had
privilege,
Whereas a man
with insight
Knows that to
keep under is to
endure.

In order to
reduce
something, it
must first be
expanded. In
order to weaken
something, it
must first be
strengthened. In
order to drop
something, it
must first be
lifted.

This is the
explanation of a
seeming
contradiction: the
tender and yielding
conquer the rigid
and strong (i.e.,
spirit is stronger
than matter,
persuasion than
force). The fish
would be foolish to
seek escape from
its natural
environment.
There is no gain to
a nation to compel
by a show of force.
up

This is the way
things are. Soft
overcomes hard.
Slow overcomes
fast. Fish cannot
live out of the
water. A nation's
best weapons
should not be
displayed. up

This is what I call
the covert
agreement. The
soft and the
weak overcome
the hard and the
strong. As a fish
out of water is in
danger, so a
nation is in peril
when its
armaments are
revealed to the
people. up

What happens to
a fish pulled out
of a pond? Or to
an implement of
state pulled out
of a scabbard?
Unseen, they
survive.

"In order to take,
a man must first
give." This is
what is called the
wisdom of light.
The soft and
weak can
overcome the
hard and strong.
Just as the fish
should not leave
the depths, The
sharp
instruments of
control should
not leave their
hiding-place. up

Chapter 37

ADMINISTERING THE GOVERNMENT Tao is apparently inactive (wu wei) and yet nothing remains undone. If princes and kings desire to keep) everything in order, they must first reform themselves.	The Tao never acts, yet through it everything gets done. If rulers could reside in the Tao, everything would fall into place all by itself.	Tao remains quiescent, and yet leaves nothing undone. If a ruler or a king could hold it, all things would of their own accord assume the desired shape.	The way to use life is to do nothing through acting, The way to use life is to do everything through being. When a leader knows this, His land naturally goes straight.	Tao is never active, but there is nothing it does not do. If princes and kings could hold onto it, all things would develop by themselves. When they develop, the desire in them would emerge, I would restrain them with simplicity, So simple that it does not even have a name, In order to liberate them from desire. Free of desire, they would be soaked in tranquillity, And thus the world would attain purity and virtue.
(If princes and kings would follow the example of Tao, then all things will reform themselves.) If they still desire to change, I would pacify them by the simplicity of the ineffable Tao. This simplicity will end desire, and if desire be absent there is quietness. All people will of themselves be satisfied. up	Action is restrained by the Tao. Action restrained, no desire. No desire: tranquillity. All things at peace. up	If in the process of transformation desire should arise, I would check it by the ineffable simplicity. The ineffable simplicity would bring about an absence of desire, and rest would come back again. Thus the world would regenerate itself. up	And the world's passion to stray from straightness Is checked at the core By the simple unnamable cleanness Through which men cease from coveting, And to a land where men cease from coveting Peace comes of course.	

Chapter 38

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	Thus, when the Tao is lost, virtue arises. When virtue is lost, morality arises. When morality is lost, justice arises. When justice is lost, propriety arises. Propriety is merely a shadow of justice, morality, and virtue; it is the beginning of chaos Therefore, the Tao■Master stays with the Tao. He does not live on the surface of things. He looks to the fruit, not to the flower. He accepts this [Tao] and rejects that [non■Tao]. up			
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Chapter 39

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	Therefore, the humble is be root of the noble; the lowly is the foundation of the high; rulers call themselves "orphans," "widows," and "worthless." This is taking the humble and the lowly as the root and foundation, is it not? You can have all the parts of a chariot without having a chariot. Better to rumble like rocks than to tinkle like jade. up		What can stand lofty with no low foundation? No wonder leaders of a land profess Their stature and their station To be servitude and lowliness! If rim and spoke and hub were not, Where would be the chariot? Who will prefer the jingle of jade pendants if He once has heard stone growing in a cliff!	
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Chapter 40

AVOIDING
ACTIVITY
Retirement is
characteristic of
Tao just as
weakness
appears to be a
characteristic of
its activity.

Reversal is the
motion of the
Tao. Yielding is
the way of the
Tao.

The path of the
Tao is backward.
The
characteristic of
Tao is
gentleness.

Life on its way
returns into a
mist, Its
quickness is its
quietness again:
Existence of this
world of things
and men
Renews their
never needing to
exist.

Going back is the
movement of the
Tao, Weakening
is the expression
of the Tao.

Heaven and
earth and
everything are
produced from
existence, but
existence comes
from
nonexistence. . .
. up

All things emerge
from being.
Being emerges
from non-being.
up

Everything in the
universe comes
from existence,
and existence
from
non-existence.
up

Everything in the
universe springs
from within
existence, And
existence springs
from
non-existence.
up

Chapter 41

When a thoughtful man hears of the Tao, he tries to follow it. When an average man hears of the Tao, he wonders about it, but then tends to forget it. When a fool hears of the Tao, he makes fun of it. If someone didn't make fun of it, it wouldn't be the Tao.

When a wise man hears the Tao, he follows it. When one of average mind hears it, he holds to it a while and presently loses it. When a foolish man hears it, he only laughs at it. If it were not held in derision by such men, it could not rightly be called Tao. Therefore, as the verse-makers would say:- Who shines with Tao is lost in shade; His path in Tao is retrograde, And all his actions are obscure.

Men of stamina, knowing the way of life, Steadily keep to it; Unstable men, knowing the way of life, Keep to it or not according to occasion; Stupid men, knowing the way of life And having once laughed at it, laugh again the louder. If you need to be sure which way is right, you can tell by their laughing at it.

Non-existence can penetrate the hardest of all. Therefore I know that there is usefulness to non-action.

Therefore, when seeking the Tao, light seems dark, advancing feels like retreating, the simple appears difficult, power is like weakness, purity seems tarnished, true virtue seems deficient and unsteady, and the clear seems obscure. The true square has no corners. The true vessel never sails. The true sound is hard to hear. The true form has no shape. The Tao is hidden, beyond definition; but it alone fulfills. up

Learning without words, usefulness without action, Only a few in the world have achieved this. up

Chapter 42

Out of Tao, One.
Out of One, Two.
Out of Two,
Three. Out of
Three, all things.
All things carry
Yin and face
Yang. Out of the
union of Yin and
Yang, harmony.

Tao emanated the
One; the one
emanated the Two;
and the two
emanated the Three.
From the Three all
things have
proceeded. All
things are backed
by the Unmanifest
and faced by the
Manifest. That
which unites them
is the immaterial
breath.
Orphanage,
isolation, and a
chariot without
wheels are
shunned by the
people; but kings
and great men
appropriate these
names to
themselves.

Life, when it came
to be, Bore one,
then two, then
three Elements of
things; And thus
the three began
-Heaven and earth
and man- To
balance
happenings: Cool
night behind, warm
day ahead, For the
living, for the dead.

Your reputation
or your person,
which is closer to
you? Your
person or your
property, which
is dearer to you?
Profit or loss,
which is worse
for you?
Over-eagerness
leads to
over-spending.

There are some
things which it is a
gain to lose, and a
loss to gain. I am
teaching the same
things which are
taught by others.
But the strong and
aggressive: ones
do not obtain a
natural death (i.e.,
self-confident
teachers do not
succeed). I alone
expound the basis
of the doctrine of
the Tao. up

No one wants to
be "orphaned," " "
widowed," or
"unworthy." But
kings and
princes use
these words as
titles for
themselves. You
win by losing.
You lose by
winning. It has
been said, and I
agree, "A violent
man dies
violently." up

For things
increase by being
deprived; and
being added to
they are
diminished. That
which people
teach by their
actions I make use
of to instruct them.
Those who are
violent and
headstrong, for
example, do not
die a natural
death. They teach
a good lesson, and
so I make use of
them. up

Though a
commoner be loth
to say That he is
only common clay,
Kings and princes
often state How
humbly they are
leading, Because
in true succeeding
High and low
correlate. It is an
ancient thought,
Which many men
have taught, That
he who
over-reaches And
tries to live by
force Shall die
thereby of course,
And is what my
own heart teaches.

Too much
property leads to
too much loss.
Therefore, the
person who is
content with his
lot will not know
disgrace, And
the person who
knows where to
stop will never
disappear, He
will exist forever.
up

Chapter 43

THE FUNCTION
OF THE
UNIVERSAL The
most tender
things of creation
race over the
hardest. A
non-material
existence enters
into the most
impenetrable.

The softest thing
overcomes the
hardest thing.
That which has
no substance
can enter where
there is no
space.

The gentlest
thing in the world
will override the
strongest. The
Non-Existent
pervades
everything,
though there be
no inlet.

As the soft yield
of water cleaves
obstinate stone,
So to yield with
life solves the
insoluble: To
yield, I have
learned, is to
come back
again.

When the learned
scholar hears the
Tao He makes
every effort to
master it. When
the mediocre
scholar hears the
Tao It will seem as
if he grasps and
loses it,
alternately. When
the weak scholar
hears the Tao He
laughs wildly, If he
had not laughed at
it, it would not be
worthy to be Tao.

I therefore
recognize an
advantage in the
doctrine of not
doing (wu wei)
and not
speaking. But
there are few in
the world who
obtain the
advantage of
non-assertion
(wu wei) and
silence. up

This shows the
value of
non-ado.
Teaching without
words; doing
without ado: hard
to accomplish.
up

By this I
comprehend how
effectual is
non-action. To
teach without
words and to be
useful without
action, few
among men are
capable of this.
up

But this
unworded
lesson, This easy
example, Is lost
upon men.

Chapter 44

PRECEPTS Which is nearer, a name or a person? Which is more, personality or treasure? Is it more painful to gain or to suffer loss? Extreme indulgence certainly greatly wastes.	Fame or self: which matters more? Self or possessions: which is more valuable? Loss or gain: which is worse? Attachment to things brings suffering.	Which is nearer to you, your name or your person? Which is more precious, your person or your wealth? Which is the greater evil, to gain or to lose?	Which means more to you, You or your renown? Which brings more to you, You or what you own? And which would cost you more If it were gone?	Tao begets one, One begets two, Two begets three, Three begets all things. All things, back to the shade, front to the light, The harmony between them is the breath of life.
Much hoarding certainly invites severe loss. A contented person is not despised. One who knows when to stop is not endangered; he will be able therefore to continue. up	Much hoarded, much to be lost. Know when enough is enough. Avoid disgrace. Know when to stop. Avoid danger. This is how to endure. up	Great devotion requires great sacrifice. Great wealth implies great loss. He who is content can never be ruined. He who stands still will never meet danger. These are the people who endure. up	The niggard pays, The miser loses. The least ashamed of men Goes back if he chooses: He knows both ways, He starts again.	What others teach, I also teach: "The cruel and violent do not die a natural death." I will use that sentence as my guide. up

Chapter 45

THE VIRTUE (TEH) OF GREATNESS Extreme perfection seems imperfect, its function is not exhausted. Extreme fullness appears empty, its function is not exercised.	The perfect seems flawed, but its usefulness is unlimited. Full seems empty, but it is inexhaustible. Straight seems bent. Intelligent seems stupid.	He who sees that his highest attainments are always incomplete may go on working indefinitely. He who sees his greatest possessions to be inadequate may go on acquiring forever.		The greatest perfection looks flawed, And even so, it never perishes. The greatest fullness looks empty, And even so, it will never run out. The straightest road looks crooked.
Extreme straightness appears crooked; great skill, clumsy; great eloquence, stammering. Motion conquers cold, quietude conquers heat. Not greatness but purity and clearness are the world's standard. up	Eloquent seems tongue■tied. Motion defeats the cold. Stillness defeats the heat. The Tao■Master remains calm as a guide for all things. up	His highest rectitude is but crookedness. His greatest wisdom is but foolishness. His sweetest eloquence is but stammering. Action overcomes cold; inaction overcomes heat. With virtue and quietness one may conquer the world. up		The greatest vigor looks like laziness, The greatest eloquence looks like stammering. Action overcomes cold, Tranquillity overcomes heat. Only through purity and tranquillity of spirit Can order be imposed on the world. up

Chapter 46

LIMITATION OF DESIRE When the world yields to Tao, race horses will be used to haul manure. When the world ignores Tao war horses are pastured on the public common.	When the kingdom is in harmony with the Tao, the horses haul manure. When the kingdom departs from the Tao, war■horses are bred in the land.	When Tao is in the world, horses are used in the pastureland. When Tao has left the world, chargers are reared in the wilderness. There is no greater sin than indulging desire.	In a land where the way of life is understood Race-horses are led back to serve the field; In a land where the way of life is not understood War-horses are bred on the autumn yield.	When Tao rules the world Racehorses are harnessed to the garbage cart in the fields. When Tao does not rule the world War-horses graze in the meadows on the outskirts of the city.
There is no sin greater than desire. There is no misfortune greater than discontent. There is no calamity greater than acquisitiveness. Therefore to know extreme contentment is simply to be content. up	There is no greater curse than wanting more than enough. There is no greater sin than greed. He who knows when enough is enough always has enough. up	There is no greater pain than discontent. There is nothing more disastrous than the greed of gain. Hence the satisfaction of contentment is an everlasting competence. up	Owning is the entanglement, Wanting is the bewilderment, Taking is the presentiment: Only he who contains content Remains content.	There is no greater sin than going after what man desires, There is no greater sorrow than not knowing a measure of contentment, There is no greater obstacle than falling into the pit of greed. Therefore, it is sufficient for you to know a measure of contentment in order to know contentment in proportion, so as to satisfy your measure. up

Chapter 47

SEEING THE
DISTANT Not
going out of the
door I have
knowledge of the
world. Not
peeping through
the window I
perceive
heaven's Tao.
The more one
wanders to a
distance the less
he knows.

You can know
the whole world
without going out
the door, You
can know the
Way of Heaven
without looking
out the window.

A man may know
the world without
leaving his own
home. Through
his windows he
can see the
supreme Tao.

There is no need
to run outside
For better
seeing, Nor to
peer from a
window. Rather
abide At the
center of your
being; For the
more you leave
it, the less you
learn.

Without crossing
the threshold of
the gate It is
possible to know
the entire world.
Without looking
through the
window It is
possible to see
the Tao of
heaven.

Therefore the
wise man does
not wander about
but he
understands, he
does not see
things but he
defines them, he
does not labor
yet he
completes. up

The further afield
you go, the less
you know. The
Tao■Master
knows without
going out;
understands
without looking;
achieves without
ado. up

The further afield
he goes the less
likely is he to find
it. Therefore the
wise man knows
without travelling,
names things
without seeing
them, and
accomplishes
everything
without action.
up

Search your
heart and see If
he is wise who
takes each turn:
The way to do is
to be.

The further the
person goes,
The less he
knows. Therefore
the sage Knows
everything
without going
through the
streets, Names
everything
without seeing it,
Accomplishes
every task
without doing
anything. up

Chapter 48

TO FORGET
KNOWLEDGE
He who attends
daily to learning
increases in
learning. He who
practices Tao
daily diminishes.
Again and again
he humbles
himself. Thus he
attains to
non-doing (wu
wei).

Pursue learning,
gain daily. Follow
the Tao, lose
daily. By losing
day■by■day,
you arrive at
non■ado.
Nothing done,
nothing left
undone.

Bodily and
mental distress is
increased every
day in the effort
to get
knowledge. But
this distress is
daily diminished
by the getting of
Tao. Do you
continually curtail
your effort till
there be nothing
left of it?

A man anxious
for knowledge
adds more to
himself every
minute; A man
acquiring life
loses himself in
it, Has less and
less to bear in
mind, Less and
less to do,
Because life, he
finds, is well
inclined,
Including himself
too.

The person who
pursues his
studies Will be
wiser with every
passing day, The
person who seeks
the Tao Will
decrease with
every passing day.
Less and less, he
will continue to
decrease, Until he
reaches the state
of non-action, And
by non-action it is
possible to do
everything.

He practices
non-doing and
yet there is
nothing left
undone. To
command the
empire one must
not employ craft.
If one uses craft
he is not fit to
command the
empire. up

Master the world
by letting things
be, by letting
them take their
own course. The
world can't be
conquered. up

By non-action
there is nothing
which cannot be
effected. A man
might, without
the least
distress,
undertake the
government of
the world. But
those who
distress
themselves
about governing
the world are not
fit for it. up

Often a man
sways the world
like a wind But
not by deed; And
if there appear to
you to be need
Of motion to
sway it, it has left
you behind.

Li Chia-mou said:
"He who pursues
learning acquires
knowledge; he
who seeks the Tao
casts off his
ignorance. The
more the person
knows, the more
he has to get rid
of. Therefore,
adding means
nothing more than
decreasing." up

Chapter 49

THE VIRTUE
(TEH) OF TRUST
The wise man has
no fixed heart; in
the hearts of the
people he finds his
own. The good he
treats with
goodness; the
not-good he also
treats with
goodness, for teh
is goodness.

The Tao■Master
does not have
his heart set on
anything in
particular. He
wants to
understand the
hearts of the
people. He is
good to people
who are good.
He is also good
to people who
aren't good. This
is true goodness.

The wise man
has no fixed
opinions to call
his own. He
accommodates
himself to the
minds of others. I
would return
good for good; I
would also return
evil for evil.
Virtue is good. I
would meet trust
with trust; I would
likewise meet
suspicion with
confidence.

A sound man's
heart is not shut
within itself But is
open to other
people's hearts: I
find good people
good, And I find
bad people good
If I am good
enough; I trust
men of their
word, And I trust
liars If I am true
enough; I feel the
heart-heats of
others Above my
own If I am
enough of a
father, Enough of
a son.

The sage has no
self that he can
call "mine," He
turns the self of
the people into his
own. I act with
goodness toward
the good, I act with
goodness toward
the bad, too, And
so the good is
contagious. I relate
with trust to the
person who is
worthy of trust, I
relate with trust to
the person who is
not worthy of trust,
too, And so trust is
contagious.

The faithful ones
he treats with good
faith; the unfaithful
he also treats with
good faith, for teh
is good faith. The
wise man lives in
the world but he
lives cautiously,
dealing with the
world cautiously.
He universalizes
his heart; the
people give him
their eyes and
ears, but he treats
them as his
children. up

He trusts people
who are
trustworthy. He
also trusts
people who
aren't
trustworthy. This
is true trust. The
Tao■Master
radiates peace
and harmony.
Through him, the
hearts of the
people are made
one. Are the
people his
children, or is he
their child? up

Virtue is trustful.
The wise man
lives in the world
with modest
restraint, and his
heart goes out in
sympathy to all
men. The people
give him their
confidence, and
he regards them
all as his
children. up

The sage lives in
the world in his
victory and rules
the world with his
simplicity. But
when all the
people look at him
and listen to him,
The sage takes
care of them, like a
mother takes care
of her children. up

Chapter 50

ESTEEM LIFE Life is a going forth; death is a returning home. Of ten, three are seeking life, three are seeking death, and three are dying. What is the reason? Because they live in life's experience.

Come into life, go into death. Three out of ten have a lust for life. Three out of ten have a lust for death. Three out of ten just pass from birth to death without appreciating either life or death. Why is this? Because none of them appreciates both life and death.

Men go forth from Life and enter into Death. The Gates of Life are thirteen in number; and the same are the Gates of Death. By as many ways does life pass quickly into Death. And wherefore? Because men strive only after the Sensuous Life. It has been said that one who knows how to safeguard Life can go through the country without protection against the rhinoceros and tiger.

Death might appear to be the issue of life, Since for every three out of ten being born Three out of ten are dying. Then why Should another three out of ten continue breeding death? By use of sheer madness to multiply.

It is easy to hold something that is motionless, It is easy to create a mold for something that is not lacking, It is easy to break something that is breakable, It is easy to scatter a thing that is small.

(Only one is immortal.) I hear it said that the sage when he travels is never attacked by rhinoceros or tiger, and when coming among soldiers does not fear their weapons. The rhinoceros would find no place to horn him, nor the tiger a place for his claws, nor could soldiers wound him. What is the reason? Because he is invulnerable. up

But there are those [one out of ten?] who appreciate both life and death. When they travel the country, they are not attacked by rhinos and tigers. When they go into battle, they are not wounded. The rhino finds nothing to gore. The tiger finds nothing to claw. Weapons find nothing to pierce. Why? Because such people have gone beyond death. up

He may enter into battle without fear of the sword. The rhinoceros finds no place wherein to drive his horn. The tiger finds no place wherein to fix his claws. The sword finds no place wherein to thrust itself. Why is this? It is because he has overcome Death. up

But there is one out of ten, they say, so sure of life That tiger and wild bull keep clear of his inland path. Weapons turn from him on the battle-field, No bull-horn could tell where to gore him, No tiger-claw where to tear him, No weapon where to enter him. And why? Because he has no death to die.

Take care of a thing before it happens, Arrange a thing before it gets out of hand. The simple man generally fails in his affairs on the verge of success. Take care of the end as you do of the beginning, And you will not fail. up

Chapter 51

TEH AS A NURSE
Tao gives life to all creatures; teh feeds them; materiality shapes them; energy completes them. p. 37
Therefore among all things there is none that does not honor Tao and esteem teh. Honor for Tao and esteem for teh is never compelled, it is always spontaneous.

Tao gives birth to the ten thousand things. Te nurtures them. They are formed from matter and completed by environment. Therefore, the ten thousand things honor Tao and respect Te, not in response to commandments, but just naturally.

Tao brings forth and Teh nourishes. All things take up their several forms, and natural forces bring them to perfection. Therefore all things conspire to exalt Tao and to cherish virtue. But this regard of Tao and Teh is not in deference to any mandate.

Existence having born them And fitness bred them, While matter varied their forms And breath empowered them, All created things render, to the existence and fitness they depend on, An obedience Not commanded but of course.

The Tao created all things, The way of the Tao nourished them, All things emerge in different forms, Each of them is perfect in the nature of the Tao within it. Therefore, there is not one among the myriad of things That does not honor the Tao and cherish its way. Honoring the Tao and cherishing its way are not dictated by law, But rather come from within.

Therefore Tao gives life to them, but teh nurses them, raises them, nurtures, completes, matures, rears, protects them. Tao gives life to them but makes no claim of ownership; teh forms them but makes no claim upon them, raises them but does not rule them. This is profound vitality (teh). up

Tao gives birth to the ten thousand things, and Te nurtures, rears, develops, shelters, and protects them. But Tao and Te do not try to own or rule the ten thousand things, nor do they seek to make them dependent. This is true power. up

It is unconstrained, and therefore it endures forever. For Tao produces all things, and Teh nourishes, increases, feeds, matures, protects, and watches over them. To produce without possessing; to work without expecting; to enlarge without usurping; this is the absolute virtue! up

And since this is the way existence bears issue And fitness raises, attends, Shelters, feeds and protects, DO you likewise Be parent, not possessor, Attendant, not master, Be concerned not with obedience but with benefit, And you are at the core of living.

Therefore the Tao creates them, makes them grow, nourishes them, Guards them, lifts them, and protects them. When all things are created, the Tao does not reject them. It creates them without owning them. It operates without depending on them, and raises them without controlling them. When its work is completed, it does not lay any claim to them. Since it does not lay claim to them, it does not lose them. up

Chapter 52

RETURN TO
ORIGIN When
creation began,
Tao became the
world's mother.
When one knows
one's mother he
will in turn know
that he is her son.
When he
recognizes his
sonship, he will in
turn keep to his
mother and to the
end of life will be
free from danger.
He who closes his
mouth and shuts
his sense gates
will be free from
trouble to the end
of life.

The world's
Source, the
Mother of all
things. Knowing
the Mother, we
know her
children.
Knowing the
children, but
holding on to the
Mother, we are
free from the fear
of death.

That from which
the universe
sprang may be
looked upon as its
Mother. By
knowing the
Mother you have
access to the
child. And if,
knowing the child,
you prefer the
Mother, though
your body perish,
yet you will come
to no harm. Keep
your mouth shut,
and close up the
doors of sight and
sound, and as long
as you live you will
have no vexation.

The source of life
Is as a mother.
Be fond of both
mother and
children but
know the mother
dearer And you
outlive death.
Curb your tongue
and senses And
you are beyond
trouble, Let them
loose And you
are beyond help.

People leave life
and enter death.
Life's portion is
three out of ten.
Death's portion is
also three out of
ten. People who
move from the day
of birth into the
realm of death,
Their portion is
also three out of
ten. Why is that?
Because of their
futile efforts to
seek eternal life.
However, only
those who do
nothing to prolong
their life, Are better
off than those who
do everything in
order to live
longer.

He who opens his
mouth and
meddles with
affairs cannot be
free from trouble
even to the end of
life. To recognize
one's
insignificance is
called
enlightenment. To
keep one's
sympathy is called
strength. He who
uses Tao's light
returns to Tao's
enlightenment and
does not surrender
his person to
perdition. This is
called practicing
the eternal. up

Stop talking,
withdraw from
the rat race,
and life is full.
Blab on, lose
yourself in
busy-ness, and
life is lost.
Seeing the small
requires good
vision. Yielding is
strength. Turn to
the Inner Light,
and find the
eternal. up

But open your
mouth, or become
inquisitive, and
you will be in
trouble all your life
long. To perceive
things in the germ
is intelligence. To
remain gentle is to
be invincible.
Follow the light
that guides you
homeward, and do
not get lost in the
darkness. This I
call using the
eternal. up

Discover that
nothing is too
small for clear
vision, Too
insignificant for
tender strength~
Use outlook And
insight, Use them
both And you are
immune: For you
have witnessed
eternity.

Chapter 53

GAIN BY INSIGHT
Even if one has
but a little
knowledge he can
walk in the ways of
the great Tao; it is
only self-assertion
that one need fear.
The great Tao
(Way) is very
plain, but people
prefer the bypaths.

If I had any sense,
I would walk on
the main road [the
Tao], and I would
fear leaving it.
Keeping to the
main road [the
Tao] is so easy,
and yet people
love to stray from it
as they seek
shortcuts. Look!

Ah that I were
wise enough to
follow the great
Tao!
Administration is
a great
undertaking. The
great Tao is
extremely
simple, but the
people prefer the
complex ways.

If I had any
learning Of a
highway wide
and fit, Would I
lose it at each
turning? Yet look
at people
spurning Natural
use of it!

The beginning of
the universe, when
materialized, is
considered to be a
mother. When a
man finds the
mother, he will
know the children,
accordingly. Even
though he knows
the children, he
still clings to the
mother: Therefore,
although his body
waned, he never
perishes. The
person who shuts
his mouth and
closes his doors
Will never perish.

When the palace
is very splendid,
the fields are likely
to be very weedy,
and the granaries
empty. To wear
ornaments and
gay colors, to carry
sharp swords, to
be excessive in
eating and
drinking, and to
have wealth and
treasure in
abundance is to
know the pride of
robbers. This is
contrary to Tao. up

The royal palace is
magnificent, but
the fields are full of
weeds, and the
granaries are
empty. Some are
beautifully dressed
and bejeweled,
wearing flashy
weapons on their
belts, eating and
drinking until they
burst. These
people■these
state■sanctioned
crooks■ have far
more than they
need. Surely, this
isn't the Tao! up

While the palace
is extremely well
appointed, the
fields may be full
of tares, and the
granaries may be
empty. To dress
grandly, to carry
sharp swords, to
eat and drink
excessively, and
to amass great
wealth, this I call
stylish theft. That
it is not Tao is
certain. up

If he opens his
mouth and
increases his
affairs, He will
never be saved.
The person who
sees the tiniest
thing possesses
clear vision, The
person who
adheres to the
weak possesses
strength. Use your
light, but dim your
brightness, In this
way you will not do
yourself any harm.
This is called
following the
eternal Tao. up

Chapter 54

TO CULTIVATE INTUITION The thing that is well planted is not easily uprooted. The thing that is well guarded is not easily taken away. If one has sons and grandsons, the offering of ancestral worship will not soon cease. He who practices Tao in his person shows that his teh is real. The family that practices it shows that their teh is abounding. The township that practices it shows that their teh is enduring.	Kapitel nicht vorhanden /	He who plants rightly never uproots. He who lays hold rightly never relinquishes. His posterity will honour him continually. Whoever develops the Tao in himself will be rooted in virtue. Whoever develops the Tao in his family will cause his virtue to spread. Whoever develops the Tao in his village will increase prosperity. Whoever develops the Tao in the kingdom will make good fortune prevail.	'Since true foundation cannot fail But holds as good as new, Many a worshipful son shall hail A father who lived true.' Realized in one man, fitness has its rise; Realized in a family, fitness multiplies; Realized in a village, fitness gathers weight; Realized in a country, fitness becomes great; Realized in the world, fitness fills the skies.	Let me have knowledge and follow the great way of the Tao, I alone am afraid of straying from this path. The great way is easy and simple, But people prefer byways. The royal palaces are wonderfully maintained, But the people's fields are full of thorns, And the barns are empty.
The state that practices it shows that their teh is prolific. The empire that practices it reveals that teh is universal. Thereby one person becomes a test of other persons, one family of other families, one town of other towns, one county of other counties, and one empire of all empires. How do I know that this test is universal? By this same Tao. up	chapter not available up	Whoever develops Tao in the world will make virtue universal. I observe myself, and so I come to know others. I observe my family, and all others grow familiar. I study this world, and others come within my knowledge. How else should I come to know the laws which govern all things, save thus, that I observe them in myself? up	And thus the fitness of one man You find in the family he began, You find in the village that accrued, You find in the country that ensued, You find in the world's whole multitude. How do I know this integrity? Because it could all begin in me.	There are those who wear expensive clothes, There are those who carry polished swords, There are those who gorge themselves on food and drink, There are those who amass property and possessions: This is called encouraging the robbers. Is this not straying from the path of the Tao? up

Chapter 55

TO VERIFY THE MYSTERIOUS The essence of teh is comparable to the state of a young boy. Poisonous insects will not sting him, wild beasts will not seize him, birds of prey will not attack him. The bones are weak, the muscles are tender, it is true, but his grasp is firm. He does not yet know the relation of the sexes, but he has perfect organs, nevertheless. His spirit is virile, indeed!	Kapitel nicht vorhanden /	The man who is saturated with Virtue is like a little child. Scorpions will not sting him, wild beasts will not seize him, nor will birds of prey pluck at him. His young bones are not hard, neither are his sinews strong, yet his grasp is firm and sure. He is full of vitality, though unconscious of his sex. Though he should cry out all day, yet he is never hoarse.	He whom life fulfills, Though he remains a child, Is immune to the poisonous sting Of insects, to the ravening Of wild beasts or to vultures' bills. He needs no more bone or muscle than a baby's for sure hold. Without thought of joined organs, he is gender Which grows firm, unfaltering.	
	chapter not available up	Herein is shown his harmony with Nature. The knowledge of this harmony is the eternal Tao. The knowledge of the eternal Tao is illumination. Habits of excess grow upon a man, and the mind, giving way to the passions, they increase day by day. And when the passions have reached their climax, they fall. This is against the nature of Tao. And what is contrary to Tao soon comes to an end. up	Though his voice should cry out at full pitch all day, it would not rasp but would stay tender Through the perfect balancing Of a man at endless ease with everything Because of the true life that he has led. To try for more than this bodes ill. It is said, 'there's a way where there's a will;' But let life ripen and then fall. Willis not the way at all: Deny the way of life and you are dead.	Therefore, when you observe the individual, know individuals, When you observe the family, know families, When you observe the village, know villages, When you observe the country, know countries, When you observe the world, know the universe. How do I know that it is possible to rule the world with the Tao? From this observation. up

Chapter 56

THE TEH OF
THE
MYSTERIOUS
The one who
knows does not
speak; the one
who speaks does
not know. The
wise man shuts
his mouth and
closes his gates.

Those who know
do not tell. Those
who tell do not
know. Stop
talking, withdraw
from the
rat■race, calm
your spirit,
untangle
yourself, soften
your glare. Be
one with the dust
of the earth.

He who knows
the Tao does not
discuss it, and
those who
babble about it
do not know it.
To keep the lips
closed, to shut
the doors of sight
and sound, to
smooth off the
corners, to
temper the glare,
and to be on a
level with the
dust of the earth,
this is the
mysterious
virtue.

Those who know
do not tell, Those
who tell do not
know.

The person who is
blessed with great
virtue can be
compared to a
child. He will not
be bitten by an
insect or a snake,
He will not be
devoured by wild
animals, Birds of
prey will not swoop
down on him. His
bones are fragile,
his tendons soft,
but his grip is
strong. He is not
familiar with the
union of man and
woman, but he
possesses
reproductive
powers.

He softens his
sharpness,
unravels his
tangles, dims his
brilliancy, and
reckons himself
with the
mysterious. He is
inaccessible to
favor or hate; he
cannot be
reached by profit
or injury; he
cannot be
honored or
humiliated.
Thereby he is
honored by all.
up

This is primal
union. Achieving
union with the
Tao places one
beyond attraction
and repulsion,
benefit and
harm, honor and
disgrace. This is
the highest state
of being. up

Whoever
observes this will
regard alike both
frankness and
reserve,
kindness and
injury, honour
and degradation.
For this reason
he will be held in
great esteem of
all men. up

Not to set the
tongue loose But
to curb it, Not to
have edges that
catch But to
remain
untangled,
Unblinded,
Unconfused, Is
to find balance,
And he who
holds baiance
beyond sway of
love or hate,
Beyond reach of
profit or loss,
Beyond care of
praise or blame,
Has attained the
highest post in
the world.

This means that
he is at the peak of
his vitality. He can
weep all day and
not become
hoarse. This
means that he is in
perfect harmony.
Being familiar with
this harmony
brings him closer
to eternity, Being
familiar with
eternity enables
man to attain
enlightenment.
Increasing life
invites trouble, Let
your heart become
addicted to the
breath of the spirit,
and you will be
filled with potency.
up

Chapter 57

THE HABIT OF SIMPLICITY The empire is administered with righteousness; the army is directed by craft; the people are captivated by non-diplomacy. How do I know it is so? By this same Tao. Among people the more restrictions and prohibitions there are, the poorer they become. The more people have weapons, the more the state is in confusion. The more people are artful and cunning the more abnormal things occur.	In governing, employ no surprises. In waging war, employ only surprises. Win the world with non-ado. How do I know this? Like this! The more rules and regulations there are, the poorer the people become. The more experts there are, the more confusion there is. The more skillful and clever technicians there are, the more horrifying inventions are produced.	The righteous man may rule the nation. The strategic man may rule the army. But the man who refrains from active measures should be the king. How do I know this:- When the actions of the people are controlled by prohibited laws, the country becomes more and more impoverished. When the people are allowed the free use of arms, the Government is in danger.	A realm is governed by ordinary acts, A battle is governed by extraordinary acts; The world is governed by no acts at all. And how do I know? This is how I know. Act after act prohibits Everything but poverty, Weapon after weapon conquers Everything but chaos, Business after business provides A craze of waste, Law after law breeds A multitude of thieves.	Make all the weapons blunt, Cut everything that is tangled, Make everything that is shiny dull, Mix with anything that is as humble as dust, And this is called absolute equality. Therefore One cannot get close to it Nor can one get away from it.
The more laws and orders are issued the more thieves and robbers abound. Therefore the wise man says: If a ruler practices wu wei the people will reform of themselves. If I love quietude the people will of themselves become righteous. If I avoid profit-making the people will of themselves become prosperous. If I limit my desires the people will of themselves become simple. up	The more "law and order" there is, the higher the crime-rate. Therefore, the Tao-Master says, I do nothing, and the people govern themselves. I practice keeping quiet, and the people find justice. I seek emptiness, and the people prosper. I have no desires, and the people return to a natural and simple life. up		Therefore a sensible man says: If I keep from meddling with people, they take care of themselves, If I keep from commanding people, they behave themselves, If I keep from preaching at people, they improve themselves, If I keep from imposing on people, they become themselves.	It is impossible to derive benefit from it, Nor to be harmed by it. It does not publicize a person's honor, Nor does it publicize a person's shame. Therefore it is the most exalted thing in the world. up

Chapter 58

ADAPTATION TO CHANGE When an administration is unostentatious the people are simple. When an administration is inquisitive, the people are needy. Misery, alas, supports happiness. Happiness, alas, conceals misery. Who knows its limits? It never ceases. The normal becomes the abnormal.	When the government is restrained, the people are happy and satisfied. When the government meddles in everything, the people are disgruntled and miserable. Happiness eclipses misery. Misery eclipses happiness. Which will it be?	A free and generous government gives the people a chance to develop. When a government is rigid and exacting the people are cramped and miserable. Misery is but the shadow of happiness. Happiness is but the cloak of misery. When will there be an end to them? If we dispense with rectitude, distortion will assert itself; and what was good in its way will give place to what is evil.	The less a leader does and says The happier his people, The more a leader struts and brags The sorrier his people. Often what appears to be unhappiness is happiness And what appears to be happiness is unhappiness. Who can see what leads to what When happiness appears and yet is not, When what should he is nothing but a mask Disguising what should not be?	
The good in turn becomes unlucky. The people's confusion is felt daily for a long time. Therefore the wise man is square, yet does not injure, he is angular but does not annoy. He is upright but is not cross. He is bright but not glaring. up	The straight becomes crooked. Good becomes evil. The people remain bewildered. Thus, the Tao■Master is sharp but not cutting, incisive but not biting, straight but not controlling, bright but not glaring. up	Verily the people have been under a cloud for a long time. Therefore the wise man is full of rectitude, but he does not chirp and carve at others. He is just, but he does not admonish others. He is upright, but he does not straighten others. He is enlightened, but he does not offend with his brightness. up	Who can but ask An end to such a stupid plot! Therefore a sound man shall so square the circle And circle the square as not to injure, not to impede: The glow of his life shall not daze, It shall lead.	

Chapter 59

TO KEEP TAO In governing the people and in worshipping heaven nothing surpasses moderation. To value moderation, one must form the habit early. Its early acquisition will result in storing and accumulating vitality. By storing and accumulating vitality nothing is impossible. If nothing is impossible then one is ignorant of his limits.	In governing the country and serving Heaven, show restraint. Showing restraint is submission to the Tao. Submission to the Tao will fill you with Te. Being filled with Te, there will be no limit to your power, and there will be nothing you cannot overcome.	In ruling men and in serving Heaven there is nothing like moderation. By means of it one attains to his first estate. When this is attained a man is possessed of an indefinite store of virtue. With such a store of virtue he will overcome everything.	To lead men and serve heaven, weigh the worth Of the one source: Use the single force Which doubles the strength of the strong By enabling man to go right, disabling him to go wrong, Be so charged with the nature of life that you give your people birth, That you mother your land, are the fit And ever-iving root of it: The seeing.	
If one does not know his limitations, one may possess the state. He who possesses moderation is thereby lasting and enduring. It is like having deep roots and a strong stem. This is of long life and enduring insight the Tao (way). up	When there is nothing you cannot overcome, you will be a true ruler indeed. You will be one with the country. You will be the Mother of the country. Being the Mother of the country, you will have deep roots and a firm base. Your reign will be long■lasting. This is the Tao of long life and eternal vision. up	And of this mastery there will be no limit. Thus, without hindrance, he may possess the Kingdom. Such a man has the mot her-constitution, and will endure indefinitely. He is like the plant whose roots are deep and whose stem is firm. Thus may a man live long and see many days. up	root, whose eye is infinite.	Otherwise, the rectification becomes a strategy, And good becomes evil. People have been aware of this for a long time. Therefore the sage is square and does not cut others, He has a point, but he does not pierce others, He is straight, but he does not straighten others, He shines, but he does not dazzle others. up

Chapter 60

TO MAINTAIN POSITION One should govern a great state as one fries small fish (i.e., do not scale or clean them). With Tao one may successfully rule the Empire.

Rule a large country as you would cook a small fish. Follow the Tao, and evil will be subdued.

The state should be governed as we cook small fish, without much business. Bringing the Tao to the governing of the Kingdom will give rest to the shades of the dead. Not that the Spirits will be inactive, but they will cease to trouble the people.

Handle a large kingdom with as gentle a touch as if you were cooking small fish. If you manage people by letting them alone, Ghosts of the dead shall not haunt you.

When ruling people, like serving heaven, the sage acts only in moderation. Only with moderation can he learn the Tao in an instant. This study is called "the rapid accumulation of a virtue." Through the rapid accumulation of a virtue He can overcome everything. Since there is nothing he cannot overcome, No one can know of his superiority.

Ghosts will not frighten, gods will not harm, neither will wise men mislead the people. Since nothing frightens or harms the people, they will abide. up

Evil will still be there, but it won't be able to do much harm. The Tao Master does no harm. If no harm is done, then the power of the Tao can flow on. up

But what is of more importance, the wise ruler of the people will not hurt them. And in so far as they do not interfere with one another, their influences conspire to the general good! up

Not that there are no ghosts But that their influence becomes propitious In the sound existence of a living man: There is no difference between the quick and the dead, They are one channel of vitality.

Since no one knows of his superiority, He can rule the country. Since what he does when he acquires everything is identified with the mother, his days are extended. Thus his roots are deep and his foundations strong, and he knows the way of longevity and immortality. up

Chapter 61

THE TEH OF HUMILITY A great state that is useful is like a bond of unity within the Empire; it is the Empire's wife. The female controls the male by her quietude and submission. Thus a great state by its service to smaller states wins their allegiance. A small state by submission to a great state wins an influence over them.

A great country is like a sea into which all streams flow, the Female of the world. The Female overcomes the Male with stillness. The woman overcomes the man by lying underneath him. Therefore, a great country dominates a small country by submitting to it; and a small country can dominate a great country by submitting to it.

The kingdom, like a river, becomes great by being lowly; it is thereby the centre to which all the world tends. It is similar in the case of woman: She conquers man by continual quietness. And quietness is the same as submission. Therefore a great state, by condescension to those beneath it, may gain the government of them.

A large country is the low level of interflowing rivers. It draws people to the sea-end of a valley As the female draws the male, Receives it into absorbing depth Because depth always absorbs. And so a large country, inasfar as it is deeper than a small country, Absorbs the small- Or a small country, inasfar as it is deeper than a large country, Absorbs the large.

Govern a large country as you would cook a small fish, gently. Let the Tao govern the world, and spirits will not roam freely. This does not mean that spirits will not have powers, But rather that their powers will not harm people.

Thus some stoop to conquer, and others stoop and conquer. Great states can have no higher purpose than to federate states and feed the people. Small states can have no higher purpose than to enter a federation and serve the people. Both alike, each in his own way, gain their end, but to do so, the greater must practice humility. up

Yield and conquer. A great country wants to unite and shelter people. A small country wants to come in and be sheltered. Each gets what it wants. Thus, the great country should yield. up

Likewise a small state, by submission to one that is greater, may secure its alliance. Thus the one gains adherence, and the other obtains favours. Although the great state desires to annex and to nourish others, yet the small state desires to be allied to and serve the greater. Thus both will be satisfied, if only the greater will condescend. up

Some countrues consciously seek depth into which to draw others. Some countries naturally have depth into which to draw others: A large country needs to admit, A small country needs to emit, And so each country can naturally have what it needs If the large country submit.

They will not harm people, Nor will the sage harm people. When neither he nor they harm anybody, The virtue belongs to both of them. When the Tao governs the world, the spirits are not known as spirits and the sage is not considered a sage, says Wang-Pi. up

Chapter 62

THE PRACTICE OF TAO The Tao is the asylum of all things; the good man's treasure, the bad man's last resort. With beautiful words one may sell goods but in winning people one can accomplish more by kindness. Why should a man be thrown away for his evil? To conserve him was the Emperor appointed and the three ministers.

The Tao is the source of all things, the good man's treasure, the bad man's refuge. You can buy beautiful words. You can build your reputation with good deeds. But even bad people can use beautiful words and perform good deeds.

Existence is sanctuary: It is a good man's purse, It is also a bad man's keep. Clever performances come dear or cheap, Goodness comes free; And how shall a man who acts better deny a man who acts worse This right to be.

A great country is like the drainage basin of the entire world, Into which all the rivers flow, It is the femininity of the entire world. Femininity always overcomes masculinity with its calmness of spirit, Which it uses as a means to lower itself. Thus the great country lowers itself before the small country, Before it conquers the small country.

Better than being in the presence of the Emperor and riding with four horses, is sitting and explaining this Tao. The reason the Ancients esteemed Tao was because if sought it was obtained, and because by it he that hath sin could be saved. Is it not so? Therefore the world honors Tao. up

So when the new emperor is crowned (and the three ministers of state are installed), do not send gifts of jade and four-horse chariots. Instead, be still, and offer the Tao. The ancients treasured the Tao because, when you seek it, you find it; through the Tao, even sinners receive forgiveness. That is why everybody loves the Tao. up

For why did the ancients hold it in such esteem? Was it not because it could be had without much seeking, and because by means of it man might escape from sin? For this it was esteemed the greatest thing in the world. up

Rather, when an emperor is crowned, let the three Ministers whom he appoints to receive for him fine horses and gifts of jade Receive for him also the motionless gift of integrity, The gift prized as highest by those ancients who said, 'Only pursue an offender to show him the way.' What men in all the world could have more wealth than they?

Chapter 63

A CONSIDERATION OF BEGINNINGS One should avoid assertion (wu wei) and practice inaction. One should learn to find taste in the tasteless, to enlarge the small things, and multiply the few. He should respond to hatred with kindness. He should resolve a difficulty while it is easy, and manage a great thing while it is small.	Act without ado; work without effort. Taste the tasteless; treat the small as large and the few as many. Reward evil with goodness. Take on the difficult while it is still easy, the large while it is still small. Difficult always begins as easy; large always begins as small.	Acting without design, occupying oneself without making a business of it, finding the great in what is the small, and the many in the few, repaying injury with kindness, effecting difficult things while they are easy, and managing great things in their beginnings, is the method of Tao.		The Tao is the source of everything, The treasure of the good man, The sustainer of the bad man. Therefore, Even the ceremonial splendor of the coronation of the emperor and his three ministers, And the value of the jewels and the knights' horses, Are nothing compared to the splendor of this Tao.
Surely all the world's difficulties arose from slight causes, and all the world's great affairs had small beginnings. Therefore the wise man avoids to the end participation in great affairs and by so doing establishes his greatness. Rash promises are lacking in faith and many things that appear easy are full of difficulties. Therefore the wise man considers every thing difficult and so to the end he has no difficulties. up	Therefore, the Tao■Master never tries to be great. As a result, he accomplishes great things. Big promises produce little trust. Treating something as quite easy makes it very difficult. The Tao■Master regards everything as difficult, which means that, for him, everything is easy. up	All difficult things have their origin in that which is easy, and the great things in that which is small. Therefore the wise man can accomplish great things without even attempting them. He who lightly assents will seldom keep his word. He who accounts all things easy will have many difficulties. Therefore the Sage takes great account of small things, and so never has any difficulty. up	The simple fact that he finds no problem big Is a sane man's prime achievement. If you say yes too quickly You may have to say no, If you think things are done too easily You may find them hard to do: If you face trouble sanely It cannot trouble you.	Why did the ancients value the Tao? Is it because it is possible to seek it and find it and liberate sinners with it? For this reason, the Tao is the most valuable thing in the world. Good words will nurture our honor, Good deeds will give a person a good name. up

Chapter 64

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Chapter 65

THE TEH OF
SIMPLICITY In the
olden days those
who obeyed the
spirit of Tao did
not enlighten the
people but kept
them simple
hearted. The
reason people are
difficult to govern
is because of their
smartness;
likewise to govern
a people with guile
is a curse; and to
govern them with
simplicity is a
blessing.

The ancient
rulers who
followed the Tao
did not try to
enlighten the
people, but
rather aimed at
making them
dull. People are
hard to govern
because they are
so clever. Rulers
who seek to
enlighten the
people are like
bandits who prey
upon the land.

The ancients who
practiced the Tao
did not make use
of it to render the
people brilliant, but
to make them
simple and natural.
The difficulty in
governing the
people is through
overmuch policy.
He who tries to
govern the
kingdom by policy
is only a scourge
to it; while he who
governs without it
is a blessing.

Sound old rulers, it
is said, Left people
to themselves,
instead Of wanting
to teach everything
And start the
people arguing.
With mere
instruction in
command, So that
people understand
Less than they
know, woe is the
land; But happy
the land that is
ordered so That
they understand
more than they
know.

In ancient times,
the best Tao
practitioners did
not use it to
educate the
people, But rather
to restore them to
simplicity. It is
difficult to govern
people since they
are very
knowledgeable.
Therefore, ruling a
country by
increasing
knowledge Means
destroying the
country, While
ruling a country by
reducing
knowledge Means
blessing the
country.

He who
remembers these
two things is a
model ruler.
Always to follow
this standard and
rule is teh, the
profound.
Profound teh is
deep indeed and
far reaching. The
very opposite of
common things,
but by it one
obtains obedient
subjects. up

Rulers who
forget about
enlightening the
people are a real
blessing to the
nation.
Remember these
two enduring
principles: they
represent the
power [Te] of the
Tao. Te goes
deep and far. All
things turn back
and reach
original harmony.
up

To know these two
things is the
perfect knowledge
of government,
and to keep them
continually in view
is called the virtue
of simplicity. Deep
and wide is this
simple virtue; and
though opposed to
other methods it
can bring about a
perfect order. up

For everyone's
good this double
key Locks and
unlocks equally. If
modern man
would use it, he
Could find old
wisdom in his
heart And clear his
vision enough to
see From start to
finish and finish to
start The circle
rounding perfectly.

The person who is
aware of these two
ways knows the
standard, The
person who keeps
the standard in his
mind is virtuous.
The highest virtue
is profound and
broad, It goes
back to the
beginning of
everything, And in
this way attains
absolute peace. up

Chapter 66

TO
SUBORDINATE
SELF The reason
rivers and seas
are called the
kings of the valley
is because they
keep below them.
Therefore the wise
man desiring to be
above his people
must in his
demeanor keep
below them;
wishing to benefit
his people, he
must ever keep
himself out of
sight.

Great rivers and
seas are kings to
hundreds of
lesser streams
because they lie
lower than the
lesser streams.
To stand above,
you must speak
from below. To
lead, you must
follow behind.

That by which the
great rivers and
seas receive the
tribute of all the
streams, is the fact
of their being
lowly; that is the
cause of their
superiority. Thus
the Sage, wishing
to govern the
people, speaks of
himself as beneath
them; and wishing
to lead them,
places himself
behind them.

Why are rivers
and seas lords of
the waters?
Because they
afford the
common level
And so become
lords of the
waters.

The best soldier
does not love
war, The best
warrior is not
bloodthirsty, The
best conqueror
does not take
part in the war,
The best
employer places
himself beneath
his workers.

The wise man
dwells above, yet
the people do not
feel the burden; he
is the leader and
the people suffer
no harm.
Therefore the
world rejoices to
exalt him and
never wearies of
him. Because he
will not quarrel
with anyone, no
one can quarrel
with him. up

This is how the
ruler who follows
the Tao stands
above and leads
the people. And
in this way, the
people are
neither
overburdened
nor oppressed.
The whole nation
supports such a
ruler. He
contends with no
one, and no one
contends with
him. up

So, while he is yet
above them, they
do not feel his
weight; and being
before them, he
yet causes no
obstruction.
Therefore all men
exalt him with
acclamation, and
none is offended.
And because he
does not strive, no
man is his enemy.
up

The common
people love a
sound man
Because he does
not talk above
their level,
Because, though
he lead them, He
follows them, He
imposes no
weight on them;
And they in turn,
because he does
not impede them,
Yield to him,
content: People
never tire of
anyone Who is
not bent upon
comparison.

That is called the
virtue of
self-control, That
is called the
ability to be
helped by others,
That is called the
enlightenment
that comes from
uniting with
heaven. up

Chapter 67

THREE TREASURES All the world calls Tao great, yet it is by nature immaterial. It is because a thing is seemingly unreal that it is great. If a man affects to be great, how long can he conceal his mediocrity? Tao has three treasures which he guards and cherishes. The first is called compassion; the second is called economy; the third is called humility.	Many consider my teaching to be nonsense. But the profound is a lot like nonsense. If a teaching does not seem nonsensical, then it must be trivial. I have three treasures to guard and preserve: The first is compassion. The second is self-restraint. The third is not wanting to be ahead of others. Compassion breeds fortitude.	All the world avows that while my Taoism is great, it is yet incompetent! It is its greatness which makes it appear incompetent. If it were like others, it would long ago have been recognized as incompetent. But I hold fast to three precious things, which I also cherish. The first is gentleness. The second is economy. The third is humility. With such gentleness I can be daring.	Everyone says that my way of life is the way of a simpleton. Being largely the way of a simpleton is what makes it worth while. If it were not the way of a simpleton It would long ago have been worthless, These possessions of a simpleton being the three I choose And cherish: To care, To be fair, To be humble.	
	Self-restraint breeds generosity. Not wanting to be ahead of others breeds leadership. These days, people want courage without compassion, generosity without self-restraint, and leadership without the willingness to be led. This is death. Compassion rules! On the attack, it wins. On the defense, it holds the fort. It is Heaven's means of aid and protection. up		When a man cares he is unafraid When he is fair he leaves enough for others, When he is humble he can grow; Whereas if, like men of today, he be bold without caring, Self-indulgent without sharing, Self-important without shame, He is dead. The invincible shield Of caring Is a weapon from the sky Against being dead.	Thus, when he is above the people, the people do not suffer at his hand, When he is at the head of the people, the people are not held back by him. Therefore the whole world wants to carry him on its shoulders And never tires of him. He competes with nobody, And therefore nobody competes with him. up

Chapter 68

COMPLIANCE
WITH HEAVEN
He who excels
as a soldier is the
one who is not
warlike; he who
fights the best
fight is not
wrathful; he who
best conquers an
enemy is not
quarrelsome; he
who best
employs people
is obedient
himself.

The best soldier
does not rush
into battle. The
best fighter does
not display his
anger. The best
conqueror does
not take
vengeance on
his enemy.

The good
commander is
not imperious.
The good fighter
is not wrathful.
The greatest
conqueror does
not wage war.
The best master
governs by
condescension.

The best captain
does not plunge
headlong Nor is
the best soldier a
fellow hot to
fight. The
greatest victor
wins without a
battle: He who
overcomes men
understands
them.

The whole world
tells me: "Great as
the Tao is, it has
no form." Since it
is great, It has no
form. If it
resembled any
form, It would have
waned a long time
ago. I have three
treasures that I
keep and
safeguard: The
first is called love,
The second is
called moderation,
The third is called
not jumping to the
head of the entire
world.

This is the virtue
of not-quarreling,
this is the secret
of bringing out
other men's
ability, this is
complying with
Heaven. Since of
old it is
considered the
greatest virtue
(teh). up

The best leader
is the best
follower. This is
known as the
power [Te] of not
contending. This
is known as true
leadership. This
is known as
following
Heaven's lead.
up

This is the virtue
of not
contending. This
is the virtue of
persuasion. This
is the imitation of
Heaven, and this
was the highest
aim of the
ancients. up

There is a quality
of quietness
Which quickens
people by no
stress:
'fellowship with
heaven,' as of
old, Is fellowship
with man and
keeps its hold.

Chapter 69

THE FUNCTION OF THE MYSTERIOUS A military expert has said: I do not dare put myself forward as a host, but always act as a guest. I hesitate to advance an inch, but am willing to withdraw a foot.

There is a saying among military strategists: "Instead of advancing, I'll be advanced upon; it is better to retreat a foot than to advance an inch." This is known as advancing without advancing, getting ready without showing your muscles, capturing without attacking, being well-armed without weapons.

A great warrior has said, "I dare not be the host, I would rather be the guest; I dare not advance an inch, I would rather retire a foot." Now this I call filling in without marshalling the ranks; baring the arms without preparing to fight; grasping the sword without unsheathing it; and advancing upon the enemy without coming into conflict.

The handbook of the strategist has said: 'Do not invite the fight, accept it instead,' 'Better a foot behind than an inch too far ahead,' Which means: Look a man straight in the face and make no move, Roll up your sleeve and clench no fist, Open your hand and show no weapon, Bare your breast and find no foe.

A tactician in ancient times said: "I do not dare to act as a host, I prefer to act as a guest, I do not dare to advance an inch, I prefer to retreat a foot." This implies that he does not muster his armies, as if he has no armies, He does not roll up his sleeves, as if his arms are not ready, He does not go out to battle, as if he has no weapons, He does not fight, as if he has no enemies.

This is advancing by not advancing, it is winning without arms, it is charging without hostility, it is seizing without weapons. There is no mistake greater than making light of an enemy. By making light of an enemy we lose our treasure. Therefore when well-matched armies come to conflict, the one who is conscious of his weakness conquers. up

There is nothing worse than underestimating your enemy. That leads to total defeat. Therefore, when armies clash, it is the side that does not rejoice in war-making that wins. up

There is nothing so unfortunate as entering lightly into battle. For in doing so we are in danger of losing that which is most precious. Thus it happens that when opposing forces meet in battle, he who feels the pity of is assuredly conquers. up

But as long as there be a foe, value him, Respect him, measure him, be humble toward him; Let him not strip from you, however strong he be, Compassion, the one wealth which can afford him.

The greatest calamity is to underestimate the strength of the enemy, For underestimating the strength of the enemy leads to the loss of our treasure of love. Therefore, when armies clash on the battlefield, The one that possesses the treasure will triumph. up

Chapter 70

THE
DIFFICULTY OF
UNDERSTANDI
NG My words
are very easy to
understand and
very easy to put
into practice, yet
in all the world no
one appears to
understand them
or to practice
them.

My teachings are
very easy to
understand and
even easier to
put into practice.
And yet, no one
understands or
practices them.
My teachings are
derived from an
ancient system
of principles.

Easy are my
words to know,
and also to
practice. Yet
none is able to
understand nor
yet to practice
them. For there
is a remote origin
for my words,
and a supreme
law for my
actions.

My way is so
simple to feel, so
easy to apply,
That only a few
will feel it or
apply it. If it were
not the lasting
way, the natural
way to try, If it
were a passing
way, everyone
would try it.

Words have an
ancestor, deeds
have a master. It is
easy to
understand my
words and practice
them. But all the
people in the world
do not know them,
And do not
practice them.
Since they have
knowledge, they
do not know me.

Words have an
ancestor (a
preceding idea),
deeds have a
master (a
preceding
purpose), and
just as these are
often not
understood, so I
am not
understood.
They who
understand me
are very few, and
on that account I
am worthy of
honor. The wise
man wears wool
(rather than silk)
and keeps his
gems out of
sight. up

People who do
not realize this
do not really
know me. Few
know me, but
that is my value.
Therefore, the
Tao■Master
wears rough
clothing, but has
a jewel for a
heart. up

Not knowing
these, men
cannot know me.
Those who know
me are few, and
by them I am
esteemed. For
the wise man is
outwardly poor,
but he carries his
jewel in his
bosom. up

But however few
shall go my way
Or feel
concerned with
me, Some there
are and those
are they Who
witness what
they see: Sanity
is a haircloth
sheath With a
jewel
underneath.

When those that
know me are few, I
am beyond all
praise. Therefore
the sage wears
coarse woolen
clothes but carries
jade jewels in his
bosom, He knows
himself, but does
not present
himself, He loves
himself, but does
not act arrogantly.
Therefore he
rejects the latter
and adopts the
former. up

Chapter 71

THE DISEASE
OF
KNOWLEDGE
To recognize
one's ignorance
of unknowable
things is mental
health, and to be
ignorant of
knowable things
is sickness.

To know that you
do not know is
strength. Not
knowing that you
do not know is a
sickness.

To know one's
ignorance is the
best part of
knowledge. To
be ignorant of
such knowledge
is a disease. If
one only regards
it as a disease,
he will soon be
cured of it.

A man who
knows how little
he knows is well,
A man who
knows how much
he knows is sick.

Not knowing
what one knows
is the best, To
think that one
knows when one
does not know is
sick.

Only by grieving
over ignorance of
knowable things
are we in mental
health. The wise
man is wise
because he
understands his
ignorance and is
grieved over it.
up

The cure begins
with the
recognition of the
sickness. The
Tao■Master is
not sick, but he is
sick of sickness.
Thus, he is well.
up

The wise man is
exempt from this
disease. He
knows it for what
it is, and so is
free from it. up

If, when you see
the symptoms,
you can tell, Your
cure is quick. A
sound man
knows that
sickness makes
him sick And
before he
catches it his
cure is quick.

Only when one
becomes sick of
this sickness, Is
it possible to get
free of the
sickness. The
sage is never
sick, Since he is
sick of this
sickness, He is
not sick. up

Chapter 72

TO CHERISH
ONE\\S SELF
When people are
too ignorant to
fear the
fearsome thing,
then it will surely
come. Do not
make the place
where they dwell
confining, the life
they live
wearisome.

When the people
do not fear your
power, then your
power has
become truly
great. Do not
intrude into their
homes. Do not
interfere with
their work.

When men do
not have a right
fear of present
dangers, they
run into extremes
of peril. Let them
beware of
enlarging the
house, being
wary of present
conditions. If
they do not
despise it, no
such weariness
will arise.

Upon those who
defy authority It
shall be visited,
But not behind
prison walls Nor
through
oppression of
their kin; Men
sanely led Are
not led by
duress.

If the people do
not fear the
ruling authority,
A much greater
fear will befall
them.

If they are let
alone, they will
not become
restless.
Therefore the
wise man while
not
understanding
himself regards
himself, while
cherishing he
does not
overvalue
himself.
Therefore he
discards flattery
and prefers
regard. up

If you do not
oppress them,
then they will not
become sick of
you. Thus, the
Tao■Master
knows himself,
but does not
show himself. He
loves himself, but
is not arrogant.
Therefore, he
lets go of that
and chooses
this. up

This is why the
Sage, while
possessed of
self-knowledge,
does not parade
himself. He
loves, but does
not value himself
highly. Thus he
can put away
pride, and is
content. up

To know yourself
and not show
yourself, To think
well of yourself
and not tell of
yourself, Be that
your no and your
yes.

Be sure that you
do not make
them live in
crowded quarters
Or make their
lives unbearable.
Only when their
living quarters
are not crowded
Will their
dissatisfaction
disappear. up

Chapter 73

ACTION IS DANGEROUS
Courage carried to daring leads to death. Courage restrained by caution leads to life. These two things, courage and caution, are sometimes beneficial and sometimes harmful. Some things are rejected by heaven, who can tell the reason? Therefore the wise man deems all acting difficult.

A man of daring courage will kill or be killed. A man of cautious courage seeks to save lives. Each of these may be either beneficial or harmful. Heaven hates what it hates. Who knows why? Even the Tao Master can't figure it out.

He whose courage is expressed in daring will soon meet death. He whose courage is shown in self-restraint will be preserved. There are, then, two kinds of courage; the one is injurious and the other of advantage. But who is to say why one of them should incur the judgement of Heaven? That is why the Sage finds it difficult to act.

A man with outward courage dares to die, A man with inward courage dares to live; But either of these men Has a better and a worse side than the other. And who can tell exactly to which qualities heaven objects?

The person who shows courage in daring will perish. The person who shows courage in a lack of daring will live. To know these two things means to differentiate between the one, which is beneficial, and the other, which is harmful. Who knows that heaven loathes one of them?

The Tao of heaven does not quarrel, yet it conquers. It speaks not, yet its response is good. It issues no summons but things come to it naturally because its devices are good. Heaven's net is vast, indeed! its meshes are wide but it loses nothing. up

The Tao does not contend, but it prevails. It does not speak, but it answers. It is not called, but it responds. It has no purpose, but it achieves all of its aims. Heaven's net is wide; nothing slips through. up

The celestial Tao does not strive, and yet overcomes everything. It does not speak, yet is skilful in replying. It does not call, yet things come to it readily. It is quiet in its methods, yet its plans are thoroughly effective. The net of Heaven has large meshes, and yet nothing escapes it! up

Heaven does nothing to win the day, Says nothing-Is echoed, Orders nothing-Is obeyed, Advises nothing-Is right: And which of us, seeing that nothing is outside the vast Wide-meshed net of heaven, knows just how it is cast?

The superior Tao does not fight, yet it wins for certain. It does not speak, yet it responds to everything. It does not call, yet everyone comes to hear it. It is not a tactician, yet it makes plans. Heaven's net is all-embracing, and its holes are wide, And even so, nothing escapes its sweep. up

Chapter 74

OVERCOMING DELUSIONS If the people do not fear death, how can one frighten them with death? If we teach people to fear death, then when one rebels he can be seized and executed; after that who will dare to rebel?

If people do not fear death, then you cannot threaten them with it. If they are afraid of death, we could make death the penalty for breaking the law. But do we dare to do so?

When the people do not fear death, of what use is it to overawe them with it as a penalty? And if they were always held in fear of death, and I could lay my hand upon all evil doers and slay them, would I dare to do it?

People starve If taxes eat their grain, And the faults of starving people Are the fault of their rulers. That is why people rebel.

When people do not fear death, What is the use of frightening them with the death penalty? When people are constantly afraid of death, And we can arrest and execute criminals, Who would dare to commit crimes?

There is always an officer to execute a murderer, but if one takes the place of the executioner, it is like taking the place of a skilled carpenter at his hewing. If one takes the place of the skilled carpenter he is liable to cut himself. (Therefore do not interfere with Tao.) up

Consider the role of the official executioner: Are you ready to play that role? When amateurs try to play the master carpenter, they usually cut and bruise themselves in the process. up

There is always the Great Executioner! For one to usurp that office is like a novice cutting out the work of a great architect. Such a one rarely fails to cut his own hands! up

Men who have to fight for their living And are not afraid to die for it Are higher men than those who, stationed high, Are too fat to dare to die.

Only the executioner kills. To kill instead of the executioner is like a woodcutter taking a master-carpenter's place. When someone carves instead of the master-carpenter, He can usually expect to injure his hand. up

Chapter 75

LOSS BY
GREEDINESS
Starvation of a
people comes
when an official
appropriates to
himself too much
of the taxes.

When taxes are
too high, people
starve. When the
government is
too intrusive, it
makes life no
longer worth
living, and the
people lose their
love of life and
their fear of
death.

The people
suffer from
famine on
account of the
heavy taxation
put upon them.
This is the cause
of their need.
The people are
difficult to govern
because of the
overbearing of
their superiors.
This is the cause
of their trouble.

Death is no
threat to people
Who are not
afraid to die; But
even if these
offenders feared
death all day,
Who should be
rash enough To
act as
executioner?

The people are
starving,
Because their
clerks impose
heavy taxes on
them. That is
why they are
starving. It is
difficult to govern
the people,
Because their
clerks interfere in
their affairs.

The reason a
people are
difficult to govern
is because the
officials are too
meddlesome; the
people make
light of death
because they are
so absorbed in
life's interests.
The one who is
not absorbed in
life is more moral
than he who
esteems life. up

To promote the
value of life, do
not interfere with
it. up

The people make
light of dying
because of the
great hardships
of trying to live.
This is the
reason for their
indifference to
death. Therefore
to keep living in
obscurity is
better than
making
overmuch of it.
up

Nature is
executioner.
When man
usurps the place,
A carpenter's
apprentice takes
the place of the
master: And 'an
apprentice
hacking with the
master's axe
May slice his
own hand.'

That is why they
are difficult to
govern. The
people do not
respect death,
Because their
clerks direct
them to seek life.
That is why they
do not respect
death. up

Chapter 76

BEWARE OF STRENGTH When a man is living he is tender and fragile. When he dies he is hard and stiff. It is the same with everything, the grass and trees, in life, are tender and delicate, but when they die they become rigid and dry.

People are born soft and flexible; when they are dead, they are hard and stiff. Living plants are tender and pliant; when they are dead, they are brittle and dried out. Therefore, whatever is hard and stiff is a sign of death.

Man at his birth is supple and tender, but in death he is rigid and strong. It is the same with everything. Trees and plants in their early growth are pliant and soft, but at the end they are withered and tough.

Man, born tender and yielding, Stiffens and hardens in death. All living growth is pliant, Until death transfixes it.

The living person is soft and pliant, and is hard and rigid in death. All creatures and plants, Are soft and vulnerable in life, And dry and brittle in death. Therefore it is said: The hard and the rigid are part of death, The soft and gentle are part of life.

Therefore those who are hard and stiff belong to death's domain, while the tender and weak belong to the realm of life. Therefore soldiers are most invincible when they will not conquer. When a tree is grown to its greatest strength it is doomed. The strong and the great stay below; the tender and weak rise above. up

Whatever is soft and flexible is a sign of life. An army without flexibility never wins. An unbending tree is easily brought down by the wind. The hard and stiff fall. The soft and flexible rise. up

Thus rigidity and strength are concomitants of death, but softness and gentleness are companions of life. Therefore the warrior who relies on his strength cannot conquer death, while the powerful tree becomes a mere timber support. For the place of the strong and the firm is below, while that of the gentle and yielding is above. up

Thus men who have hardened are 'kin of death' And men who stay gentle are 'kin of life.' Thus a hard-hearted army is doomed to lose. A tree hard-fleshed is cut down: Down goes the tough and big, Up comes the tender sprig.

This is the reason why soldiers who are too rigid Do not triumph. When the tree is too rigid, it will break. The stance of the strong and the great is stooped, The stance of the weak and the small is erect. up

Chapter 77

TAO OF HEAVEN
Tao of heaven resembles the stretching of a bow. The mighty it humbles, the lowly it exalts. They who have abundance it diminishes and gives to them who have need. That is Tao of heaven; it depletes those who abound, and completes those who lack. The human way is not so.

The Tao is like the bending of a bow. The top is bent downward; the bottom is bent up. If the cord is too long, it is shortened; if it is too short, it is lengthened. The policy of the Tao is to take from those who have too much and give to those who have too little. But that is not the human practice.

Like the bending of an archer's bow is the Tao of Heaven! It brings down that which is high, and raises up that which is depressed. It takes away where there is excess, and gives where there is deficiency. The Tao of Heaven makes all things equal. This Tao is not of man.

Is not existence Like a drawn bow? The ends approach, The height shortens, the narrowness widens. True living would take from those with too much Enough for those with too little, Whereas man exacts from those with too little Still more for those with too much.

Is not the superior Tao like drawing a bow? The high part moves downward, the low part moves upward, What is full is reduced, what is insufficient is filled. The superior Tao reduces the full, fills what is insufficient. Man's Tao, in contrast, takes from the insufficient and gives to the full.

Men take from those who lack to give to those who already abound. Where is the man who by his abundance can best serve the world? The wise man makes but claims not, he accomplishes merit, yet is not attached to it, neither does he display his excellence. Is it not so? up

We take from those who have too little and give to those who have too much. Who is it that has more than enough and gives his surplus to those in need? Only the follower of the Tao. The follower of the Tao acts without hope of gain, accomplishes but takes no credit, does not wish to lord it over others. up

Man takes from the needy to add to his own excess. Who is he that, having a superabundance, can bring it to the service of the world? Only he who has the Tao. This is why the wise man acts without expectation of reward, and completes his task without claiming merit. For thus he hides his wealth. up

Now what man shall have wealth enough to share with all men Save one who can freely draw from the common means? A sane man needs no better support, no richer reward, Than this common means, Through which he is all men's equal.

Who can take from the full and give to the insufficient? Only he who has the Tao can. Therefore, the sage does not hoard anything for himself. The more he helps others, the more he obtains for himself. The superior Tao does good, and never does evil, The sage's Tao acts, but never hurts others. up

Chapter 78

TRUST AND FAITH In the world nothing is more fragile than water, and yet of all the agencies that attack hard substances nothing can surpass it. Of all things there is nothing that can take the place of Tao. By it the weak are conquerors of the strong, the pliable are conquerors of the rigid.

Water is soft and yielding, but nothing can more effectively dissolve the hard and inflexible. Weak defeats strong. Soft defeats hard. This is well-known, but not easy to put into practice.

Nothing on earth is so weak and yielding as water, but for breaking down the firm and strong it has no equal. This admits of no alternative. All the world knows that the soft can wear away the hard, and the weak can conquer the strong, but none can carry it out in practice.

What is more fluid, more yielding than water? Yet back it comes again, wearing down the rigid strength Which cannot yield to withstand it. So it is that the strong are overcome by the weak, The haughty by the humble.

The weakest thing in the world can overcome the strongest thing in the world. Nothing in the world can compare with the weakness of water, whose nature is limp and submissive, But when it attacks the hardest and strongest of all, there is nothing more efficient, Since there is no alternative to it.

In the world every one knows this, but none practice it. Therefore the wise man declares: he who is guilty of the country's sin may be the priest at the altar. He who is to blame for the country's misfortunes, is often the Empire's Sovereign. True words are often paradoxical. up

Therefore, the Tao-Master says: He who takes upon himself the dirt of the nation becomes the master of its sacred soil; he who takes upon himself the evils of the land becomes a true king under Heaven. Straight words seem crooked. up

Therefore the Sage says: He who bears the reproach of his country is really the lord of the land. He who bears the woes of the people is in truth their king. The words of truth are always paradoxical. up

This we know But never learn, So that when wise men tell us, 'He who bites the dust Is owner of the earth, He who is scapegoat Is king,' They seem to twist the truth.

The weak can overcome the strong, and the soft can conquer the tough: The whole world knows that, but does not abide by it. Therefore the sage says: The person who bears all the disgrace of the country can be the master of the land, The person who bears all the troubles of the country can be the king of the world. These are words of truth, Even though they sound like nothing more than a paradox. up

Chapter 79

ENFORCING CONTRACTS When reconciling great hatred there will some remain. How can it be made good? Therefore the wise man accepts the debit side of the account and does not have to enforce payment from others.	Great resentment, even when appeased, does not go away. How can this be good? Therefore, the Tao■Master keeps his promises, but he does not look into whether others are keeping theirs.	When a compromise is effected after a long dispute, one of the parties retains a grudge: how can this be called a good settlement? Therefore the wise man takes his part of the bond, and does not insist upon having the other.	If terms to end a quarrel leave bad feeling, What good are they? So a sensible man takes the poor end of the bargain Without quibbling.	Give love in return for fierce hatred. Otherwise, when the fierce hatred is forgotten, A little of it will still remain. And how can this end well? Therefore the sage keeps the left half of a contract, And does not check what the other holder has to do.
They who have virtue (teh) keep their obligations, they who have no virtue insist on their rights. Tao of heaven has no favorites but always helps the good man. up	The man of virtue (Te) monitors himself; The man without virtue monitors others. The Tao of Heaven plays no favorites, but it is always manifest in the good man. up	The virtuous man attends only to his engagements in the bond, while the man without virtue contrives for his own advantage. The Tao of Heaven has no favourites; it always aids the good man. up	It is sensible to make terms, Foolish to be a stickler: Though heaven prefer no man, A sensible man prefers heaven.	The virtuous person acts according to the contract, The person who is not virtuous resorts to lawsuits and disputations. "The superior Tao is not biased, It always accompanies the virtuous person." up

Chapter 80

CONTENTMENT

In a small country with few people let there be officers over tens and hundreds but not to exercise power. Let the people be not afraid of death, nor desire to move to a distance. Then though there be ships and carriages, they will have no occasion to use them. Though there be armor and weapons there will be no occasion for donning them.

Imagine a small country with a small population. They have lots of technology, but they use none of it. They take the prospect of death seriously and thus do not travel far from home. They have boats and carriages, but no one takes them out. They have weapons and armor, but no one takes them out of the armory. Instead of writing, they have gone back to the old system of cord■knotting.

If I had a small kingdom and but ten or a hundred men of ability, I would not administrate with them. I would teach the people to look upon death as a grievous thing, and then they would not go abroad to meet it. Though they had boats and carriages, yet they would not go away in them. Though they had armour, yet they would never have occasion to wear it.

Imagine a small land with few people. Even if it contains plenty of vessels, I will not use them. I will induce the people to respect death, and not to go wandering far afield. Even if they have boats and chariots, they will not travel in them, Even if they have weapons and armor, they will not bear them. I will bring them back to knotted cords instead of writings.

The people can return to p. 52 knotted cords for their records, they can delight in their food, be proud of their clothes, be content with their dwellings, rejoice in their customs. Other states may be close neighbors, their cocks and dogs may be mutually heard, people will come to old age and die but will have no desire to go or come. up

They enjoy their plain but good food, their simple but fine clothing, their humble but secure homes. They are happy with their way of life. The next country is so close that the crowing of the cocks and the barking of the dogs over there can be easily heard over here; and yet the people over here grow old and die without ever having been over there. up

Though so close to their own town another town grow They can hear its dogs bark and its roosters crow, Yet glad of life in the village they know, Where else in the world shall they need to go?

Their food will satisfy them, Their clothing will please them, Their dwellings will be full of tranquillity, Their customs will be full of happiness. Even though the neighboring lands are within view, And the crowing of the roosters and the barking of the dogs from there are audible, The people of that small country will not go there in their lifetime. up

Chapter 81

THE NATURE OF THE ESSENTIAL
Faithful words are often not pleasant; pleasant words are often not faithful. Good men do not dispute; the ones who dispute are not good. The learned men are often not the wise men, nor the wise men, the learned.

True words aren't pretty; pretty words aren't true. The good do not contend; those who contend aren't good. The wise are not learned; the learned are not wise. The Tao■Master is not greedy.

Sincere words are not grand. Grand words are not faithful. The man of Tao does not dispute. Those who know it are not learned. The learned do not know it. The wise man does not lay up treasure. The more he expends on others, the more he gains for himself.

He who knows does not speak, He who speaks does not know. He who speaks the truth is not arrogant, He who is arrogant does not speak the truth.

The wise man does not hoard, but ever working for others, he will the more exceedingly acquire. Having given to others freely, he himself will have in plenty. Tao of heaven benefits but does not injure. The wise man's Tao leads him to act but not to quarrel. [no frames]

The more he does for others, the more he has. The more he gives to others, the richer he becomes. The Tao sharpens without cutting. The Tao■Master acts with non■ado. [no frames]

The more he gives to others, the more he has for his own. This is the Tao of Heaven, which penetrates but does not injure. This is the Tao of the wise man, who acts but does not strive. [no frames]

He who has good qualities does not argue, He who argues does not have good qualities. He who has learned a lot does not know, He who knows has not learned a lot. Therefore the sage does not display his qualities.